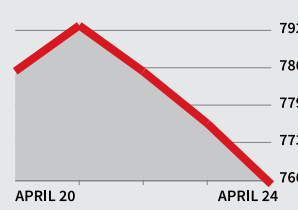


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 76664.21 (-999.79)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23897.95	-275.10
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.98	-0.33
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.24	+0.14
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	150872.00	+418
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	243825.00	+3229



FARM RELIEF.

Centre raises wheat procurement target, eases norms, urges millers to buy as farm gate prices fall p8

AUTO FOCUS.

Aerox E disappoints with poor performance and comfort, fails to match Yamaha legacy expectations p4

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

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QUICKLY.

MAJOR JOLT

AAP splits as 7 of 10 RS MPs shift to the BJP



New Delhi: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) headed for a major split on Friday as seven of its 10 Rajya Sabha members joined the BJP. The members include Raghav Chadda, Sandeep Phatak, Ashok Mittal, Harbhajan Singh, Rajinder Gupta, Vikramjeet Sahney and Swati Maliwal. After this, the AAP has Sanjay Singh and Narain Dass Gupta from Delhi and Sant Balbir Singh from Punjab in the Rajya Sabha. **p9**

INCOME SURGE

IndusInd Bank posts Q4 profits of ₹533 crore

Mumbai: IndusInd Bank reported a standalone net profit of ₹533 crore in Q4FY26 on the back of a healthy growth in net interest income and other income, even as its deposits and advances declined. The Bank had reported a net loss of ₹2,236 crore in the year-ago quarter as it made a provision of ₹2,417 crore due to incorrect recording of cumulative interest income and fee income, among others. **p3**

Sapped by energy business, Reliance Ind Q4 net dips 12.6%

GROWTH PUSH. Full-year PAT jumps 16% on strong show by telecom, retail and investment gains

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Reliance Industries reported a 12.6 per cent fall in consolidated net profit in the fourth, or March, quarter of FY26, falling well short of analyst estimates, due to a weakness in its energy businesses, which offset strong earnings growth in digital services and positive contribution from retail.

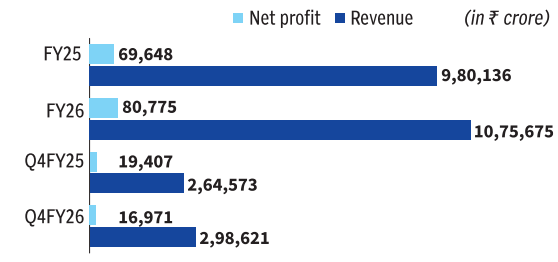
Consolidated revenue for the quarter rose nearly 13 per cent year-on-year to ₹2.99 lakh crore, while EBITDA remained largely flat at ₹48,588 crore. EBITDA margin shrank 200 basis points to 14.9 per cent.

For the full year, however, the company delivered record financials. Annual revenue rose 9.8 per cent to ₹10.76 lakh crore, while EBITDA increased 13.4 per cent to ₹2.08 lakh crore.

Profit after tax jumped 16 per cent to ₹80,775 crore, supported by strong contributions from telecom and retail, along with gains from investments.

Chairman Mukesh Ambani said the company navigated a challenging global environment marked by geopolitical tensions and volatile energy prices, aided by its diversified portfolio and domestic focus.

Consolidated scorecard



The telecom arm, Jio Platforms, remained the standout performer. Quarterly EBITDA grew 17.9 per cent year-on-year to ₹20,060 crore, driven by subscriber additions and higher average revenue per user at ₹214. “We are advancing steadily towards the listing of Jio Platforms,” said Ambani.

The sharp increase in fuel cracks was offset by rising crude premiums on physical barrels, elevated logistics and fuel costs, as well as unavailability of advantaged crude.

It was further hit by under-recoveries in fuel retailing and the reintroduction of special additional excise

nited from expansion in store footprint, which crossed 20,000 outlets, and a rapid growth in hyperlocal commerce.

ENERGY PRESSURE

In contrast, the O2C segment saw margin pressures despite higher revenues, as global volatility, rising crude premium and logistics disruptions weighed on profitability.

It was further hit by under-recoveries in fuel retailing and the reintroduction of special additional excise

RETAIL ‘STEADY’

Reliance Retail Ventures delivered a steady performance, with quarterly EBITDA rising 3.1 per cent to ₹6,921 crore. The segment benefited from expansion in store footprint, which crossed 20,000 outlets, and a rapid growth in hyperlocal commerce.

duty. O2C revenue rose 12.4 per cent to ₹1.84 lakh crore, but EBITDA fell 3.7 per cent to ₹81,540 crore.

WEST ASIA CRISIS

RIL reacted to the West Asia crisis by resorting to Persian Gulf loading contracts to minimise run cuts, while working with suppliers there on alternative routing for standard crude.

Similarly, the oil and gas segment reported declining earnings due to lower production and realisations. It also maintained refinery-linked and ethane feedstock for uninterrupted downstream operations.

Reliance continued to invest aggressively in future growth, with capital expenditure rising to ₹40,560 crore in Q4 from ₹33,836 crore in Q3 and ₹1.44 lakh crore for the full year. The company also announced a dividend of ₹6 per share. Looking ahead, the company is betting on its digital ecosystem, retail expansion and new energy ventures as key growth engines, even as traditional energy businesses face near-term headwinds.

Also read p2

India steps up spot LPG buys from US with West Asia supplies still under cloud

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

State-run oil marketing companies (OMCs) are increasing their liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) purchases from the US by adding more spot cargoes, amid continued uncertainty over supplies of cooking and heating fuel from West Asia.

Sources said that the move is to meet LPG supply shortfalls due to the West Asia conflict. “OMCs already have a long-term contract with the US. As West Asian supplies remain uncertain, they have turned to the US,” said one of the sources.

SUPPLY BOOST

India has already increased its LPG sources from 10 to 15. Last month, the Oil Ministry said 8,00,000 tonnes of assured inbound LPG cargoes had been secured and were *en route* from the US, Russia, Australia and other countries.

On US spot LPG cargoes, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Petroleum Ministry, said, “We will buy LPG from wherever it is available.”

Despite repeated efforts to normalise transit conditions through the Strait of Hormuz, LPG exports from West Asia remained largely subdued at 1,50,000 barrels per day in April (1-21). Saudi



EXPORT SLUMP. Despite efforts to normalise transit through the Strait of Hormuz, West Asia LPG exports remained subdued at 150,000 barrels per day in April

Arabia LPG exports via Yanbu remain unchanged m-o-m at around 110,000 b/d, constraining the upside for the region’s VLGC (very large gas carrier) utilisation, Vortexa said.

The market intelligence firm, in its monthly LPG report for April, said that global exports of the key fuel recovered after falling more than 1 million b/d (mb/d) since early March. The US Gulf Coast LPG exports are at near-record levels at around 2.4 mb/d.

“Global LPG exports show signs of recovery with April volumes surpassing the 5-year seasonal average on a near-record US sendout (exports),” Vortexa said.

“Propane exports show more resilience, while butane balances continue to remain tight with emerging markets competing (South

East Asia, India, etc) for less-common, but growing US butane cargoes,” the market intelligence firm added.

S&P Global Energy CERA last month said India is increasingly turning to the US for LPG as geopolitical tensions reshape global trade flows.

If the West Asia conflict continues for a long period, there is a chance for North American LPG to gain a stronger foothold in India’s import mix.

FALLING IMPORTS

India’s weekly LPG imports fell to 2,65,000 tonnes in the week to March 19 from 3,22,000 tonnes on March 5. West Asian inflows to India declined to 89,000 tonnes in the week to March 19, representing only 34 per cent of total imports, the lowest since January.

For IT majors, revenue lags deal wins surge on shift to large, AI-led, outcome-based contracts

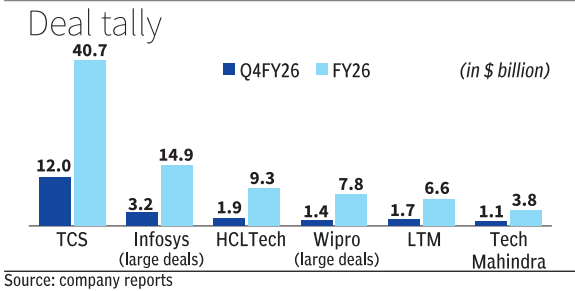
Sanjana B
Bengaluru

India’s top IT services firms are seeing a growing gap between strong deal wins and muted revenue growth as a shift towards large, AI-led, and outcome-based contracts delays conversion of bookings into near-term revenues.

Sidhant Rastogi, President, Zinnov, noted that TCS, Infosys, HCLTech and Tech Mahindra reported a combined TCV (total contract value) of \$68.7 billion in FY26 against a reported revenue of roughly \$60 billion during the fiscal year.

CONVERSION LAG

“Historically, the cohort ran at 32-35 per cent first-year conversion; in FY26, it converted at closer to 28 per cent. Three factors explain the



Source: company reports

compression. First, AI-embedded transformation programmes now take 9-12 months from signing to revenue, versus 4-6 months for traditional staffing deals. Second, deal size has grown materially. Third, a rising share of wins are outcome-based or AI-co-created contracts, where revenue follows value delivery, not effort. The gap reflects that the deals being signed are structurally more valuable than the deals of two years ago,” he said.

Piyush Goel, CEO and Founder of Beyond Key, echoed this, adding that the lag between orders and revenues is a product of the complexity of solutions, implementation, and time required for proper rollout and adoption. “Many recent successes relate to enterprise-wide digitalisations and AI implementations, for which a comprehensive discovery, integration strategy, and staged roll-out are prerequisites. Thus, there is a logical lag

between signing and recognising the revenues. Customers value result-oriented deployments, which take longer to realise but create greater value for longer periods. This is a sign of a shift towards large and more strategic deals,” he said.

C Vijayakumar, CEO and MD, HCLTech, during the Q4 conference call, said, “Apart from a sequential decline, we saw a delay in procurement decisions in March that resulted in revenue coming below our expectations,” with US telecom spending cuts and SAP-related cancellations flagged as the specific drivers.

Rastogi said that as firms shift from input-based billing to outcome- and platform-led contracts, revenue recognition becomes back-loaded to milestones rather than linear, making conversion assumptions less reliable.

RBI shuts Paytm Payments Bank over compliance failures, cites risk to depositors

Our Bureau
Mumbai

It is curtains for Paytm Payments Bank Ltd (PPBL). The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has cancelled its licence with effect from the close of business on April 24.

The central bank cited PPBL’s non-compliance with various provisions of the Banking Regulation Act for its action.

The RBI highlighted that the affairs of PPBL were being conducted in a manner detrimental to the interests of the bank and its depositors, and that it failed to comply with the licensing conditions.

This is the first time that a payments bank is being shuttered by the RBI after it started issuing licences for these niche lenders in 2015-



16. With this, the number of payments banks shrinks to five — Airtel Payments Bank, India Post Payments Bank, Fino Payments Bank, Jio Payments Bank and NSDL Payments Bank.

WINDING ACTION

“The RBI will make an application for winding up of the bank [PPBL] before the High Court... PPBL has enough liquidity to repay its entire deposit liability upon winding up of the bank,” per a central bank statement.

Some of the other reasons cited by the RBI for cancelling PPBL’s licence include the general character of the management of the bank being prejudicial to the interest of depositors, as also the public interest, and that no useful purpose or public interest would be served by allowing the bank to continue.

COMPLIANCE LAPSES

Paytm Payments Bank came in the regulatory crosshairs due to certain material supervisory concerns relating to adherence to KYC norms and compliance systems and repeated regulatory violations, among others.

The regulatory noose around the bank started to tighten after March 2022, when the RBI directed it to stop onboarding new customers. The bank was also directed to appoint an audit

firm to conduct a comprehensive audit of its IT systems.

Thereafter, on January 31, 2024, and February 16, 2024, certain business restrictions were also imposed on the bank which, *inter alia*, disallowed any further deposits/credits/top-ups in existing customer accounts, prepaid instruments, wallets, etc.

In the wake of the regulatory action, the Vijay Sekhar Sharma-promoted One 97 Communications Ltd, which owns the Paytm platform, started transitioning the services provided by PPBL to other partner banks to ensure continued services for its customers and merchants.

Besides payments, Paytm is now also into lending, insurance distribution and financial products (mutual funds, stocks and bonds via Paytm Money).

Seaplane ahoy! All set for water-taxi services

SkyHop Aviation to get flying licence after clearing regulatory trials

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The wait for an amphibious taxi may soon be over. SkyHop Aviation is all set to receive its flying licence — air operator permit (AoP) — after it successfully cleared regulatory trials for its seaplane services, sources familiar with the development told *businessline*.

The AoP will make it India’s first dedicated scheduled seaplane flight services provider, akin to an airline, whereas in the past, there have been several non-scheduled amphibious operations by other companies that fizzled out over time.

FLIGHT PLANS

Sources said the regulatory clearance marks a key operational milestone for the Avani Singh-led aviation



AMPHIBIOUS AIRCRAFT. SkyHop has secured a Twin Otter DHC-6-400 series aircraft, equipped with floats for water landing

venture as it prepares to launch seaplane services in India. Avani Singh is the daughter of Ajay Singh, SpiceJet’s Chairman and Managing Director.

The company had earlier moved forward with infrastructure and aircraft acquisition plans while awaiting approvals. According to sources, the company has secured a Twin Otter DHC-6-400 series aircraft equipped with floats for water landing.

LANDING JETTIES

Besides, the company has completed the construction of dedicated jetty infrastructure at five islands in Lakshadweep at its own cost. The initial focus is expected to be on connecting mainland India with islands in Lakshadweep, while discussions continue for the induction of additional aircraft.

Notably, the venture received a no-objection certificate along with mandatory

security clearance in June last year. Further, float testing for water landing had been completed before the licensing stage.

Previously, SkyHop had highlighted that only around 170 of India’s nearly 4,000 cities currently had air connectivity. The company stated that its seaplanes and small aircraft were aimed at improving access to under-served regions.

India currently has no operational seaplane service. The segment had briefly seen activity in 2019-20 when a seaplane service operated between the Sabarmati riverfront and the Statue of Unity in Gujarat before being discontinued during the Covid-19 period. A decade ago, Maritime Energy Heli Air Services (Mehair) had taxied off waterways in the Andamans.

Markets reel for third straight session, dragged by sell-off in IT stocks, rising crude oil prices

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Markets closed lower for the third consecutive session on Friday, with the Nifty 50 shedding 275 points or 1.14 per cent to end at 23,898 — its steepest single-day fall in April — as a brutal sell-off in IT stocks and surging crude oil prices compounded an already fragile market mood.

The Sensex fell 983 points to close at 76,681, with every sectoral index ending in the red.

IT ROUT

The Nifty IT index bore the brunt, cratering over 5 per cent after Infosys and HCL Tech delivered subdued earnings outlooks, rattling investor confidence in one of India’s most closely watched sectors.

Infosys and TCS led the index laggards, while Coal India and Trent offered rare

bright spots as the session’s top gainers.

While the Nifty50 fell 1.87 per cent for the week, the Sensex plunged 2.3 per cent after posting two weeks of gains. The Nifty IT was the worst performer, plummeting 10.31 per cent.

GLOBAL HEADWINDS

The sell-off unfolded against a deteriorating global backdrop. Brent crude climbed above \$100 a barrel as the stand-off at the Strait of Hormuz showed no signs of easing, keeping energy supply risks firmly in play.

“Markets are currently pricing in a level of optimism that appears disconnected from the underlying geopolitical and energy realities,” said Justin Khoo, Senior Market Analyst at VT Markets, adding that “energy supply chains do not normalise as quickly as market sentiment”.

Institutional flows re-

Under pressure

	Weekly change (%)
Nifty	-1.87
Nifty Next50	-0.55
Nifty Bank	-0.84
Nifty Midcap150	-0.77
Nifty SmallCap250	-0.15
Nifty IT	-10.31

mained a concern. FIIs returned to net selling after a brief reprieve, while the broader market breadth deteriorated sharply with 383 of 500 Nifty stocks closing in the red, and the BSE advance-decline ratio at 0.46.

The macro picture received another blow this week as both JP Morgan and HSBC downgraded Indian equities — JP Morgan to ‘Neutral’ and HSBC to ‘Underweight’ — citing earnings downgrades, rich valuations and India’s vulnerability to oil price shocks.

JP Morgan estimated that

an extreme oil scenario of \$120 per barrel could shave 2 per cent off the GDP and 3 per cent off earnings. HSBC flagged that “valuations will appear elevated as earnings downgrades feed through,” and noted that India looks less attractive than its north-eastern Asian peers in the current environment.

RISK OUTLOOK

Looking ahead, the markets will track crude oil movements closely, with any further deterioration in Hormuz shipping flows likely to pile pressure on the rupee and corporate margins.

The ongoing Q4FY26 earnings season, particularly management commentary on FY27 guidance, will be a key near-term trigger. Immediate support for the Nifty lies in the 23,550-23,600 zone, while a recovery above 24,200 would be needed to shift the short-term bias back in favour of bulls.

QUICKLY.

Chalet Hotels acquires Udaipur resort for ₹171 cr



Mumbai: Chalet Hotels has acquired Inder Residency Resort & Spa in Udaipur for ₹171 crore, making a foray into Rajasthan. Inder Residency Resort has 144 rooms spread over 8.2 acres and the property will be upgraded to upper upscale premium lifestyle destination. The K Raheja Corp-owned company owns 11 hotels across the country. OUR BUREAU

JSW Motors-Tata Elxsi tie up for tech centre in Pune

Mumbai: JSW Motors and Tata Elxsi signed a pact on Friday to establish a joint R&D facility in Pune, marking a significant step in India's push toward software-defined electric vehicles. The facility, named JNEXT – JSW NextGen Technology Center, will function as an engineering hub for developing connected vehicle platforms covering electric vehicles, hybrids and plug-in hybrids. OUR BUREAU

ARPU growth, services drive Reliance Jio's Q4 net up 13%

GAINING TRACTION. Total user base stood at 524.4 m, with sequential growth of 1.7%

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Reliance Jio Infocomm reported a 13 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) rise in net profit to ₹7,935 crore in the quarter ended March 31, and revenue increased 12.7 per cent on the back of organic ARPU growth, an improving subscriber mix in mobility, a scale-up of home connects and a growth in digital services.

Its EBITDA rose to ₹20,060 crore — a quarterly growth of 3.9 per cent and a 17.9 per cent y-o-y increase, aided by higher revenue and strong operating leverage that drove a 190 basis points expansion in margins.

SUBSCRIBER GROWTH Subscriber base grew 7.4 per cent y-o-y, while ARPU rose 3.8 per cent to over ₹214 per month per subscriber. The total subscriber base stood around 524.4 million, with sequential growth of 1.7 per cent. Monthly churn was 1.7 per cent, and net subscriber ad-

Strong subscriber base

	Q4 FY25	Q3 FY26	Q4 FY26
Gross revenue (₹ cr)	39,853	43,683	44,928
EBITDA (₹ cr)	17,016	19,303	20,060
Profit after tax (₹ cr)	7,022	7,629	7,935
Customer base (million)	488.2	515.3	524.4
ARPU (₹ per subscriber per month)	206.2	213.7	214

ditions were 9.1 million. On a sequential basis, net profit rose 4 per cent and gross revenue grew 2.8 per cent.

Akash M Ambani, Chairman of Reliance Jio Infocomm, said, “Jio’s state-of-the-art connectivity and edge compute infrastructure make it the principal gateway through which AI services reach Indian consumers.”

DATA TRAFFIC Data traffic hit 66 billion GB, a 5.9 per cent sequential increase and 35 per cent y-o-y growth. Per capita data consumption was 42.3 GB per month. Voice traffic remained flat while Jio’s True5G subscribers reached 253 million.

JioAirFiber reported 13 million subscribers. Mukesh D Ambani, RIL

JioStar Q4 profit dips 52% sequentially

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Reliance Industries’ media arm JioStar reported a sequential dip of 52 per cent in its profit at ₹419 crore even as revenue increased by 22 per cent to ₹9,784 crore with an EBITDA of ₹827 crore for the quarter ending March 31. JioStar reported a net profit of ₹3,210 crore and gross revenue of ₹36,248 crore for FY26. The network led in key

Chairman and Managing Director, said, “I am happy to note that we are advancing steadily towards the listing of Jio Platforms. This will mark a defining milestone in its journey as it continues to scale new heights and contribute to India’s digital future. Robust full-year EBITDA growth of 19 per cent was driven by continuing traction in mobility, home broadband and enterprise services.”

markets with its TV entertainment viewership share at 34.2 per cent share, reaching over 810 million viewers nationally. The viewership share was close to the combined share of the next three biggest networks. JioHotstar averaged 500 million Monthly Active Users (MAUs) in Q4, with the T20 Men’s Cricket WC Final reporting 72.5 million peak concurrency, the highest ever for any property and a global record, as per a release.

Reliance Retail logs stable Q4 growth amid margin pressures

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Reliance Retail Ventures reported steady growth in the fourth quarter of FY26, with strong momentum in hyper-local commerce and continued expansion of its store network, even as margins remained under pressure due to ongoing investments. The company posted gross revenue of ₹98,232 crore for the quarter, up 10.8 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y), while revenue from operations rose 11.1 per cent to ₹87,344 crore, supported by broad-based growth across consumption categories.

EBITDA increased 3.1 per cent year-on-year to ₹6,921 crore, with margins down 60 bps at 7.9 per cent, reflecting continued spending to scale its hyper-local commerce capabilities. Profit after tax rose marginally by 0.5 per cent to ₹3,563 crore.

ONLINE CHANNELS Operationally, the retail giant continued its aggressive expansion, adding 333 stores during the quarter to take the total count to 20,160 outlets, spanning 78.3 million sq. ft. Its registered customer base grew 10.9 per cent year-on-year to 387 million, while transactions surged 62 per cent to 585

Scorecard

	Q4FY25	Q4FY26
Revenue from operations (₹ cr)	78,622	87,344
PAT (₹ cr)	3,545	3,563
EBITDA (₹ cr)	6,711	6,921
EBITDA margin %	8.5	7.9

million, highlighting rising consumer engagement. Growth was particularly strong in digital and quick commerce channels. JioMart saw hyper-local daily orders jump 29 per cent sequentially and more than triple year-on-year, with its network now covering over

5,100 pin codes across 1,200 cities. Fashion platform Ajio expanded its catalogue to around 3 million products, while its quick delivery service Ajio Rush scaled to over 600 cities with a four-hour delivery promise. In other segments, the consumer electronics business saw strong traction from promotional campaigns, while the jewellery segment benefited from rising gold prices, driving a 53 per cent increase in average bill value.

FMCG BRANDS Reliance Consumer Products more than doubled

its revenue in the quarter to ₹7,350 crore, while for the full year it doubled to ₹22,000 crore, led by Campa and Independence brands. Campa notched up sales of over ₹4,700 crore in FY26 while Independence achieved sales of ₹2,600 crore. Expansion in supply chain network, acquisitions and new brand launches across categories aided in the company’s growth. It was further scaling up capacity to become one of the largest beverages makers in the world and adding high speed bottling lines across several greenfield plants in 12 States.

Mercedes-Benz calls for another price hike in July

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi



The CLA 250+ ‘Long Range’ model is priced at ₹59 lakh

Mercedes-Benz India on Friday said the buying sentiments for luxury cars in India have not changed, as the markets are getting back to normalcy. It is the delay in supply chain management, which the carmaker said, was leading to price escalation, and that it was planning for another price hike in the next few months. “We were never dependent on the current shipping routes, which are affected. We are seeing delays, we are seeing increased cost for sure, but it’s still in the manageable extent because we anyway have buffer stocks. But, on the other side, the exchange rate deterioration was significant so we tried to cover it with two price increases already and now we have to again think of the

third price increase in the third quarter (July),” Santosh Iyer, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, Mercedes-Benz India, told *businessline*. Speaking on the sidelines of the much awaited CLA battery electric vehicle (BEV), he noted that the company has to recalculate at some point in time, because rising exchange rates were the worrying factor, more than the supply side. “We have to be careful on the demand side as well – that we cannot continue to

increase prices and expect demand to be the same. So we will have to recalculate that at some point in time,” Iyer said. **ROBUST DEMAND** On the demand side, he said that there was a strong momentum for luxury cars with significant demand, and the industry is expected to continue with the momentum. “It was only in the last week of March when we saw a bit of some sentiment changes. That was the week when the capital markets

crashed and there was a bit of sentiment down. But now, with the recovery of the markets as well as to some extent, I think the buying sentiments have not changed, we still are seeing good demand,” Iyer added. The company launched the CLA BEV with introductory prices of ₹55 lakh for CLA 200 ‘Standard Range’; ₹59 lakh for CLA 250+ ‘Long Range’; and ₹64 lakh for CLA BEV ‘Launch Edition’. The CLA 250+ ‘Long Range’ has a range of 792 km on a full charge, goes 0-100 kmph in 6.7 seconds and has a 200 kW peak output with 85.5 kWh battery. Mercedes-Benz India has already received 400+ bookings and the deliveries will soon commence, Iyer said, adding that 60 per cent of buyers are first time buyers to luxury and 40 per cent are current luxury customers. Majority of CLA buyers are Gen Z and millennials.

TNPL profit rises in FY26 on deferred tax restatement

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Ltd on Friday reported a net profit of ₹240 crore for Q4 FY26 against ₹22 crore logged in the year-ago period on the back of reversal of deferred tax liability (net) due to opting for the new tax regime. Revenue from operations stood at ₹1,271 crore (₹1,336 crore). Both the quarterly and full-year profit were up due to the restatement of deferred tax liability, which was to the tune of ₹219 crore for the year. For FY26, net profit is ₹248 (₹4 crore). The company reported full-year revenue of ₹4,645 crore (₹4,491 crore). The cost of producing zinc

CPCL triples Q4 net profit at ₹1,400 crore

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai



H Shankar, MD, CPCL BUOY GHOSH

Chennai Petroleum Corporation Ltd (CPCL), a subsidiary of Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), reported a sharp surge in profitability for the fourth quarter ended March 31, with net profit more than tripling to ₹1,400 crore, compared with ₹450 crore in the year-ago period, even as revenue remained flat at

₹20,455 crore in Q4FY26 versus ₹20,581 crore in Q4FY25. Its net profit jumped over 17x to ₹3,062 crore from ₹174 crore in the previous fiscal. Revenue for the fiscal rose 9 per cent to ₹78,611 crore, up from ₹71,050 crore. **SUPPLY CHAIN** H Shankar, Managing Director, CPCL, told *business-*

line that despite the West Asia situation, the company managed to maintain near-full capacity operations, aided by support from IOC. The refinery temporarily halted Russian crude processing following sanctions, before resuming limited crude processing. Alternative supplies were secured from Sudan, Ghana and Gabon, besides occasional cargoes from the US, he said. Traditionally, around 55 per cent of CPCL’s crude is sourced through term contracts — largely from West Asia — with the rest coming from spot purchases and domestic supply. CPCL processed 2.93 million tonnes (mt) of crude during the quarter, marginally lower than 2.97 mt in the year-ago period. Capacity utilisation stood at a robust

112 per cent. For the full year, crude throughput rose to 11.71 mt from 10.45 mt a year earlier. To manage price volatility and supply uncertainty, CPCL adopted a dynamic inventory strategy, reducing stock levels during periods of rising crude prices and blending available grades to sustain operations, he noted. The refinery is also exploring additional sourcing options routed via the Red Sea, said Shankar. **RETAIL EXPANSION** On the downstream front, CPCL has begun expanding into fuel retailing, commissioning its first outlet at Nemam, near Chennai. It is targeting around 100 retail outlets during the current fiscal, with ₹400 crore earmarked for the same.

Adani Green to invest ₹15,000 crore in BESS

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad



Adani Green Energy Ltd (AGEL) is accelerating its battery energy storage system (BESS) expansion with planned investments of around ₹15,000 crore, as part of a broader FY27 capital expenditure programme pegged at approximately ₹45,000 crore. A large share of the current build-out is concentrated at the company’s flagship renewable energy complex in Khavda, Gujarat. At the same time, Rajasthan is being positioned as a major next frontier for BESS deployment. Executive Director Sagar Adani on Friday said the company had already added 1.4 GW of battery capacity at

Khavda over the past year and is on track to cross 3 GWh of installed storage capacity in the coming days. At that scale, he noted, AGEL would account for nearly half of India’s operational battery storage capacity. The company is using largescale battery systems to address transmission constraints in renewable-rich regions, enabling solar power generated during the

day to be stored and dispatched during evening peak demand hours. “We expect to commission more than 10 GWh of battery storage this year,” Adani said. Overall, AGEL’s FY27 capex of around ₹45,000 crore includes approximately ₹15,000 crore earmarked for BESS. **Q4 RESULTS** On Friday, AGEL reported a 34 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) rise in consolidated net profit at ₹514 crore for the March quarter. The RE arm of the Adani Group recorded a ₹52-crore write-off during the quarter related to the withdrawal from a 434 MW wind power project in Mannar and Pooneryn in Sri Lanka, part of a series of one-off items that weighed on its full-year prof-

itability. Revenue growth during the quarter remained steady, with total income rising 14 per cent to ₹3,727 crore, while revenue from power supply increased 16 per cent to ₹3,094 crore. For FY26, however, the company’s net profit declined 0.7 per cent to ₹1,987 crore, despite total income rising 11 per cent to ₹13,819 crore. The muted annual performance was impacted by multiple exceptional items, including refinancing costs, project exits and liquidated damages. These included the Sri Lanka project write-off, ₹24 crore in liquidated damages paid for exiting a power purchase agreement, and ₹178 crore in one-time refinancing costs linked to prepayment of borrowings across subsidiaries.

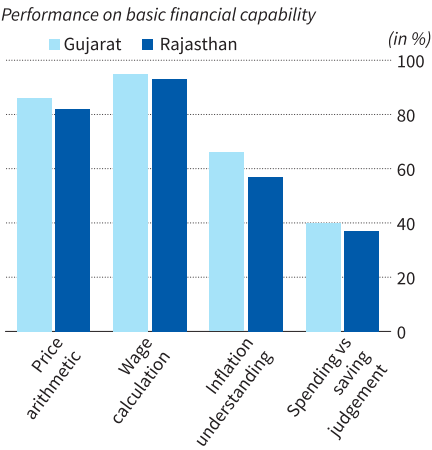
VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Yashaswani Chauhan** | Graphic: **Visveswaran V**

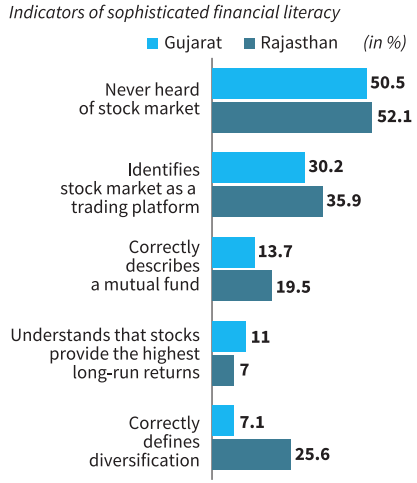
Gaps in financial maturity

Financial inclusion in India has expanded rapidly, but the Financial Maturity Index (FMI) report 2026 by the Indian Institute of Management, Udaipur, and People Research on India’s Consumer Economy shows that access to banking and digital tools has not translated into stronger financial capability. Based on a household survey across Gujarat and Rajasthan, the report finds that while more people are part of the formal financial system, gaps in planning, risk awareness, and long-term preparedness remain. The survey included 4,075 households, out of which 1,884 were from Gujarat and 2,191 were from Rajasthan

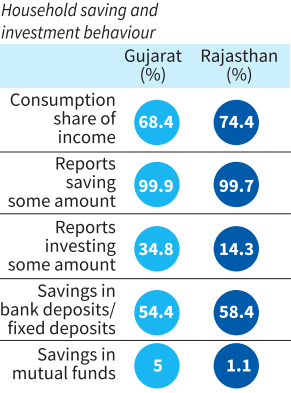
Basic financial skills are strong for arithmetic but weaker for inflation and savings decisions



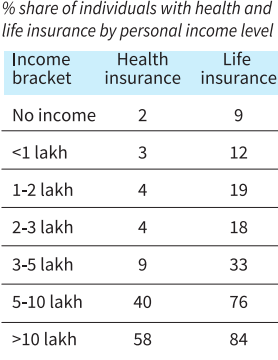
Less than one in five respondents understand mutual funds



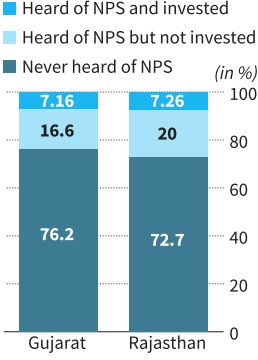
Nearly all households save, but only a small fraction invests



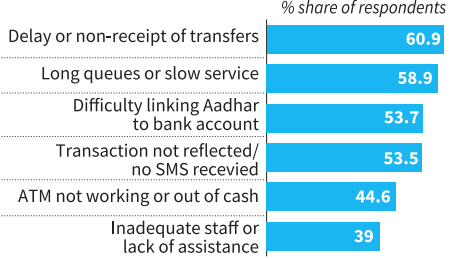
Insurance coverage rises with income but remains inadequate for many households



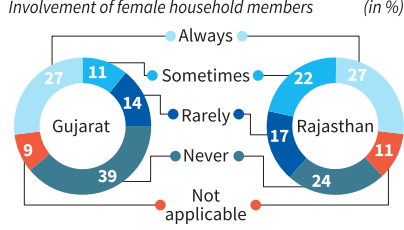
Retirement planning remains limited with low awareness of formal pension schemes



Key difficulties in accessing banking services and welfare transfers



Women's participation in financial decision-making remains lower than men's



Source: Financial Maturity Index Report by Indian Institute of Management, Udaipur, and People Research on India’s Consumer Economy

Hindustan Zinc Q4 net surges 68%

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Hindustan Zinc, a Vedanta Group company, reported that its net profit in the March quarter was up 68 per cent at ₹5,033 crore against ₹3,003 crore logged in the same period last year — the highest profit growth in 20 quarters — largely due to a sharp rise in silver and other metal prices. Revenue increased 44 per cent to ₹12,692 crore (₹8,829 crore) — the best in 19 quarters. EBITDA increased 61 per cent to ₹7,747 crore (₹4,816 crore). Silver revenue more than doubled to ₹4,032 crore (₹1,688 crore). Revenue from zinc was up 19 per cent at ₹6,997 crore (₹5,856 crore) while that from lead and others increased 12 per cent and 164 per cent to ₹1,153 crore and ₹1,362 crore respectively. The company’s refined metal production was up 5 per cent at 2.82 lakh tonne in the quarter under review. The cost of producing zinc

Shine stays

	Q4 FY25	Q4 FY26
Net profit (₹ cr)	3,003	5,033
Revenue (₹ cr)	8,829	12,692
EPS (Diluted) (₹)	7.11	11.91

was down 9 per cent at \$903 per tonne on account of lower power cost driven by higher domestic coal usage and softened coal prices, higher by-product realisation, better mined grades and increased metal production, said the company. The company further strengthened its long-term growth outlook, with record ore resources and reserves of 468.6 million tonnes, supporting a mine life of over 25 years and surpassing 13.9 million tonnes of metal reserves and 1.09 lakh tonnes of silver reserves for the first time, it said.

CAPEX TOP UP

It announced a capex of \$500-\$600 million in FY27. It expects mined mineral and

metal production to increase to 11.5 lakh tonnes and 11 lakh tonnes in FY27. Silver output is expected at 680 tonnes while cost of production of zinc was at \$975-\$1,000 per tonne in this fiscal. As of March-end, the company had gross investments and cash equivalents of ₹13,846 crore in high quality debt instruments. Total borrowings outstanding was at ₹8,252 crore. The company expects to complete its 5.1 tonnes per annum fertilizer plant and innovative hot acid leaching technology for recovery of lead and silver from smelting waste at Dariba by the September quarter. **‘MINE’STONE OF 1.1 MT** Arun Misra, Chief Executive Officer, said the company’s full year mined metal production crossed a key milestone of 1.1 million tonnes. “We have also delivered the lowest cost of production of despite the ongoing geopolitical challenges with the focus on strong execution and unwavering focus on value creation,” he said.

businessline.

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QUICKLY.

KTM 390 Duke with 349 cc engine launched at ₹2.77 lakh



The downsized Duke is primarily built to slip under India's 350 cc GST threshold. With the 349 cc mill, it produces 41 bhp and 3.4 kg-m; the 398.6 cc motor, making 45 bhp and 4.0 kg-m, now forms the 390 Duke R. The move cuts prices by over ₹60,000, while keeping features unchanged, effectively splitting the Duke line into a more affordable everyday option and a sharper, higher-tax performance variant.

BMW F 450 GS available from ₹4.7 lakh onwards



One of the most anticipated bikes of the year has finally made its debut, marking BMW's shift to a twin-cylinder platform in the entry-level ADV space. Powered by a 420 cc parallel-twin producing 47 bhp and 4.4 kg-m, it replaces the G 310 GS and is built in India. With 19/17-inch wheels, 180-mm suspension travel and a 178-kg kerb weight, the new baby GS promises a good blend of road and off-road use.

Tesla Model Y L released in India



The American electric vehicle company has expanded its India portfolio with the launch of the Model Y L, a long-wheelbase, three-row version of its electric SUV, priced ₹61.99 lakh (ex-showroom). The new variant features a dual-motor all-wheel-drive setup, a range of up to 681 km and a 0-100 kph time of around 5 seconds. With a 2+2+2 seating layout and added cabin space, it targets premium family buyers.

@TheMotorGram



RUMAN DEVMANE

Ruman Devmane

I'd only just gotten off a happy morning astride the lovable Yamaha EC-06. The setting, somewhere on the outskirts of Lonavala, had lent itself wonderfully to riding an electric scooter and, to my delight, there was another one I had ample time to spend with — the Aerox E.

The Yamaha Aerox 155 has, so far, set the standards for what scooters with a performance bent should aspire to be like. It isn't flawless and while it comes with an undeniable comfort deficit, it feels quintessentially 'Yamaha' — that really matters.

Therefore, I expected no difference on the Aerox E which, on the face of it, has been designed with a clear brief: Live up to the Yamaha legacy, the Aerox nameplate and set the standards for what electrified performance should feel like. Not a daunting task for a manufacturer as proficient as Yamaha, you'd think. Somehow, the Aerox E does no such thing. Not even remotely.

Visually, there's no sign of this. Yamaha offers it in white only and the teal highlights, including the swing arm-mounted motor, do enough to distinguish it from the ICE version. It paints a neat picture, seeing as the Aerox is an inherently racy-looking scooter and to imagine it going about its expected behaviour, albeit in a hushed manner, isn't unappealing at all. Yamaha has upped the switchgear quality in the process and has also added a disc brake at the rear, along with ABS and traction control.



NOT SO BRILLIANT. The Aerox E gets quality switches and a neat instrument screen. The seat is quite uncomfortable, and the removable batteries heavily cannibalise underseat storage

NOT FOR LAUGHS

A set of two 1.5-kWh batteries power the Aerox E and, on paper, the 12.6 bhp it produces sounds exciting. Paper isn't fun to ride, though, and neither is the Aerox E. No, not in comparison to the Aerox 155. It just isn't. Period. Just to reinforce context, it wasn't as if I'd hopped off a powerful motorcycle with no palette cleanser in between; I'd spent a few hours astride the EC-06, an electric scooter made by an EV start-up funded by Yamaha itself. That scooter had me grinning for the most part.

Things went sour much before I got to that bit, however. Now, the Aerox has always looked past comfort in its sporty outlook but the Aerox E is, in a way, worse. When I took off with it from the parking



bay, I pulled over almost immediately to check if I'd left the seat open. I hadn't. There's a strange contour to the seat that feels a bit like sitting on a helmet (don't ask how I know) although, to the Aerox E's credit, my mind was soon taken off that concern and onto other glaring ones. Such as the ergonomics.

With the absurdly shaped seat also being forward-sloped — just as the floorboard is — you'll find yourself in a needlessly aggressive riding position with your knees practically level with the handlebar. It's not much different from riding a scooter while standing up. Oh, and the Aerox E, at 139 kg, is 13 kg heavier than the Aerox 155. If you thought the bad news was over, I'll have to disappoint you.

Off the mark

WHY YAMAHA? The electrification of its performance flagship scooter, the Aerox, hasn't quite gone to plan. We try to wrap our heads around it

STRANGER THINGS

My test route had a slightly rough patch of tarmac before opening up to a really smooth curvy section and, on the Aerox E, this felt torturous. The suspension, carried over from the regular Aerox, is simply too firm at the rear and equally soft at the front-end, which results in a ride that's unacceptably thrashy and crude. Premiumness? Look away, please! To be fair, an Aerox isn't built for bad roads; it's for really fun, fast bits of urban tarmac which, I knew, were my reward for enduring this uneven section. Unfortunately, when I got there, that reward was conspicuously absent.

The Aerox E is neither fast nor fun. It shockingly lacks any form of punchy attitude, no matter what level of performance you're accustomed to. Of the three modes it offers, I stayed in Power for the most part — as you would on a scooter of this class — and was crestfallen at its lack of spiritedness. Sure, there is a boost mode that lasts 10 seconds (can be re-accessed only after a 30 second interval) but, even then, it felt only moderately more exciting. The saving grace is that, unlike on the EC-06, you can switch modes with the throttle engaged which is a blessing if you're in one of the lower modes (Eco, Standard) and need to execute a quick overtake.

The one redeeming aspect of the Aerox E is its handling. With 14-inch wheels at either end and ample contact patches, courtesy the Ceat Zoom Plus Y tyres, the Aerox E feels comfortably agile and poised all at once. Here, it benefits from the Aerox's inherent dynamism although its compromised ergonomics ruin this flavour to a large extent, too.

Braking is, thankfully, predictably sharp and it takes really aggressive inputs to get the Aerox E to lose composure.

TRY ANOTHER DAY

What's the range on offer? Yamaha claims 117 km (IDC) although my test scooter, under a riding style that was less than favourable, seemed to lose charge quite rapidly. I, for one, don't mind a trade-off in range for impeccable performance but since that's sorely lacking on the Aerox E, it's a struggle to make peace with.

Charging isn't exactly a breeze either. The Aerox E deploys two removable batteries (13 kg each) under its seat; it takes a touch over 3 hours to charge each battery with the 650 W charger it's supplied with, and it offers single-battery functionality, too, with a further drop in performance. Not really tempting, then, especially seeing as the Aerox E is rumoured to sport a price tag that's in excess of ₹2 lakh. No typo, that.

Is there any reason you should buy an Aerox E, then? No. I thought long and hard (what else was there to do astride it anyway?) to find some ray of hope in the Aerox E and simply couldn't find any. See, I get that the Aerox E isn't born-electric such as the EC-06; it's a retrofit and that's no bad thing except that it properly feels like one. Think of it as a college project at best, and not even the winning entry. If you still absolutely must have one, I suggest you wait for the discounts that should follow its launch. Better still, get yourself an Aerox 155 and leave saving the planet to someone else.

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Faired Play

ALL ABOUT SPEED. The BMW S 1000 RR Pro M Sport is German exotica at its pinnacle. That you can buy one, no questions asked, is nothing short of a miracle

Ruman Devmane

I had no business being hunched down over the BMW S 1000 RR's low-set handlebar. I'm not a racer and, from where I was on the outskirts of Pune, there was no racetrack in sight. Given the S 1000 RR's performance credentials, it should have felt like overkill in this scenario. Yet, it didn't.

At daybreak, I was already snaking up a beautiful hillside road, barely exploring its performance potential. A quick glance at its comprehensive TFT display revealed I had short-shifted all the way up to sixth gear — at all of 60 kph. In fact, the S 1000 RR will let you putter around at even slower speeds, all the while without losing its linear acceleration even though that's completely not the point of a motorcycle of this stature.

In reality, the S 1000 RR is meant to decimate lap records and offer nearly racebike levels of precision. It revels in its long-standing rivalry with Ducati's flagship, the phenomenal Panigale V4, and has proven itself to be far superior than its Japanese peers on the world stage over the years. While its credentials reflect seriousness, it also happens to be a really friendly motorcycle to ride, as I learned over the course of the morning.

Okay, the riding position isn't

ideal if you're overweight — it's properly committed, as you'd expect — but once you've adapted, the S 1000 RR is so rewarding. True to its spec sheet, everything on the S 1000 RR is top-notch and especially as a part of this special Pro M Sport package, it gets you some really fancy bits. The carbon wheels are beautiful and light, the brakes are tack-sharp, the Pirelli Diablo Rossi III tyres are brilliant and the suite of rider assists (a core BMW strength) empower you to take strong liberties with the throttle.

FIERCE FINESSE

Thanks to its 999 cc inline-four, eye-watering acceleration is standard and so is the accompanying refinement. While the Panigale V4 is certainly more dramatic and quite a lot more uncouth, the S 1000 RR opts to stay predictable, relatively speaking. Our photography spot, for instance,

involved briefly traversing a tricky off-road trail and the S 1000 RR still ploughed through unflinchingly, although I was mindful of preserving its expensive and fragile carbon fibre wheels.

Show it a stretch of minty blacktop though, and it instantly delivers on its promise of unapologetic performance. The S 1000 RR is fierce and finessed, all at once, and for a 206-bhp motorcycle with a 197-kg kerb weight, it's incredibly controlled and encouraging. It doesn't need a lot of room to hit 100 kph from standstill (3.2 seconds, claimed) or to get to its 303-kph top speed and, especially with the Akrapovic exhaust this version is specced with, it produces the most irresistible howl. Your neighbours won't be too impressed about that, though.

I couldn't, unfortunately, take it around fast-paced corners but if its moderate-speed cornering is anything to go by, the S 1000 RR

has no disappointment in store for you. It's a precision instrument for riders committed to track-racing and, for anything below that, it's always got way more to offer than you'll legally have room for.

Objectivity? Oh, that's so futile! There's nothing it'll do in the real world that a motorcycle half its price won't — and with greater comfort — but that isn't why you'd buy one anyway. The S 1000 RR is a pretty good representation of the dreams most of us pursued and moved on from, for reasons of practicality, while some among us persisted. Buying one is a hugely emotional, irrational moment in your motorcycling arc and, if you can afford the ₹28.9 lakh (ex-showroom) BMW is asking for it, it's a no-brainer. Just don't forget to sign up for every trackday out there, please!

@TheMotorGram



SYSTEMS CHECK. The bike gets you top-flight tech. Rider interface is crisp and intuitive, along with gorgeous carbon wheels on the Pro M Sport package



YASH GAWDE

QUICKLY.

Swedish co MTG's arm
PlaySimple files DRHP



New Delhi: Swedish gaming firm Modern Times Group MTG AB on Friday said its wholly-owned Indian subsidiary PlaySimple Games Ltd has filed draft papers with the market regulator to launch a ₹3,150 crore initial public offering (IPO). The IPO will be entirely an OFS, with MTG acting as the promoter and selling shareholder. As a result, the proceeds from the issue will accrue to MTG, according to the draft papers filed on Thursday. As per the draft papers, the offer size is expected to be up to ₹3,150 crore (about \$350 million). The final issue size may vary within permissible limits and will be decided closer to the opening of the offer. ■

PropShare Celestia units
end over 1% lower

New Delhi: The units of PropShare Celestia ended over 1 per cent lower on their trading debut on Friday. Earlier in the day, the units started trading at ₹9,99,900.01, a decline of 4.77 per cent from the issue price of ₹10,50,000 per unit on the BSE. It later ended at ₹10,35,000, down 1.42 per cent. The company's market valuation stood at ₹241.16 crore. PropShare Celestia's initial public offering received 1.33 times subscription on the closing day of the issue on Thursday last week. PropShare Celestia is the third Small and Medium Real Estate Investment Trust launched by Property Share Investment Trust. The ₹244-crore issue had a price band of ₹10-10.5 lakh per unit. ■

BROKER'S CALL.

Motilal Oswal

FORTIS HEALTHCARE (BUY)

Target: ₹1,100
CMP: ₹928.10
After the change in promoter ownership to IHH Healthcare in FY19, Fortis Healthcare (FORH) has undergone a structural transformation, from a stressed, governance challenged asset to a professionally managed, execution-led hospital platform. The transition was marked by balance sheet clean-up, exit of non-core assets and strengthening of governance practices. Since then, FORH has delivered a steady improvement in operating performance, from sales/EBITDA of ₹45b/₹2b and a loss of ₹1.5b in FY18 to sales/EBITDA/PAT of ₹9,000 crore/₹2,050 crore/₹1,080 crore over FY26E. During FY18-FY26, FORH has significantly increased its bed capacity and improved its operational efficiency, driving a 33 per cent CAGR in EBITDA. We value FORH on the SoTP basis, valuing the hospital business at 30x 12M fwd EV/EBITDA and the diagnostics business at 23x 12M fwd EV/EBITDA, to arrive at a target price of ₹1,100. We have assigned EV/EBITDA multiple in line with peers (MAXH/APH/PS) to factor in the robust transformation in the existing business, a brownfield strategy of bed additions driving faster EBITDA break-even, and subsequently driving better return ratios. We initiate coverage on FORH with a Buy rating.

Emkay Global

UTI AMC (ADD)

Target: ₹1,200
CMP: ₹924.50
UTI Asset Management has delivered a largely stable MF QAAUM (quarterly average asset under management) in Q4-FY26 at ₹3.9 lakh crore (~1.4 per cent q-o-q), despite market volatilities. However, revenue at ₹375 crore fell about 5 per cent q-o-q on dip in revenue yields to 39.1bps driven by shift in mix towards passive funds. Q4 EBITDA margin stood at 39.3 per cent, but was impacted by higher other expenses. During FY26, the company undertook multiple initiatives — including expanding geographic presence, investments in technology, strengthening the sales force, and deepening distributor relationships — while maintaining focus on cost. Growing the MF AUM remains the single-line strategic priority of the management. Further, the management emphasised that growing the SIP book would remain the core agenda and the key metric for the sales team. Investments in digital capabilities are likely to drive new SIP registrations, led by the young cohort. Also, with growth in AUM, the management remains focused on managing costs and increasing efficiency. To bake in the Q4 developments, we tweak our estimates which results in about 2-3 per cent cut in PAT over FY27-28E owing to higher other expenses. Going forward, consistent investment performance and sustained flows led by an expanding distribution network remain key to driving AUM growth. We maintain Add on UTI Asset Management while raising Mar-27E target price by about 9 per cent to ₹1,200 (from ₹1,100) implying FY28E P/E of 18x.

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SEBI proposes revamp of variable net worth norms for stockbrokers

CASH RESERVES. Draft paper seeks to align capital requirements with operational risk and client base

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has proposed a significant overhaul of the way stockbrokers calculate their variable net worth, seeking to better align capital requirements with the scale and nature of their operations. The regulator said the existing framework, introduced in 2022, may no longer be effective following structural changes in the handling of client funds.

CLIENT FUNDS
Under current rules, brokers are required to maintain variable net worth equivalent to 10 per cent of the average daily cash balance of clients retained over the previous

six months. However, with the introduction of the upstreaming framework, most client funds are now transferred to clearing corporations, leaving minimal balances with brokers. “Consequently, calculation of variable net worth of the brokers based on availability of funds with them may not be an effective way,” the regulator said in the draft paper on Friday. To address this gap, SEBI proposed a revised methodology that factors in multiple parameters, including average client credit balances and the number of active clients serviced by brokers, both directly and through authorised persons (APs). Net worth acts as a “second line of defence (first being margin)” and must be robust enough to absorb



WAR CHEST. The intent is to ensure that brokers serving a large number of clients have a sufficient financial cushion to absorb losses or unforeseen circumstances ■■

risks not covered by margins, SEBI said. “It is imperative that the second line of defence should be strengthened by making the net worth requirement commensurate with the size and risks of operations,” it said. Brokers would need to

maintain variable net worth based on an aggregate of metrics. **CREDIT BALANCE** These include 10 per cent of the average credit balance of clients over six months, along with fixed slabs linked to the number of active cli-

ents. For instance, brokers with more than 10,000 direct clients would be required to maintain an additional ₹50 lakh, with incremental requirements for larger client bases. Similarly, client accounts routed through authorised persons would attract separate capital requirements, starting from ₹5 lakh and scaling up based on volume. “The intent is to ensure that brokers serving a large number of clients have a sufficient financial cushion to absorb losses or unforeseen circumstances,” SEBI said. The move follows recommendations from a working group comprising stock exchanges and broker associations. Market participants have until May 15 to submit their comments on the proposal.

Regulator allows net settlement for FPIs in cash segment Uniform price band for F&O stocks on the cards

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India has introduced a framework permitting net settlement of funds for transactions undertaken by foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) in the cash market shifting from the existing gross settlement mechanism. It said the change is intended to ease liquidity pressures and reduce transaction costs for overseas investors. Under the current system, FPIs are required to meet ob-

ligations on a gross basis at the custodian level, even though custodians settle on a net basis with clearing corporations. **TO EASE LIQUIDITY** “Representations were received from market participants highlighting that the gross settlement of transactions results in additional liquidity requirements, increased funding costs due to forex slippage and operational inefficiency for FPIs, particularly during days of index rebalancing,” it said. The new framework is to be implemented on or before

December 31. The objective is to enhance operational efficiency and reduce cost of funding for FPIs. However, transactions in securities having both purchase and sale transactions in a settlement cycle shall be excluded from netting and shall continue to be settled on gross basis. Further, settlement of securities shall continue to be carried out on a gross basis between FPI and custodian, SEBI said. The framework also specifies that if outright sales exceed outright purchases, the excess cannot be adjusted against other obligations.

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is considering applying dynamic price bands for stocks forming part of any exchange's derivatives segment in order to improve trading consistency and price discovery, according to people aware of the discussions. So if a stock is part of the futures and options (F&O) segment on any one exchange, it would move to dynamic price bands across all exchanges. This plugs the gap that currently leaves room for short-lived but meaningful inconsistencies between exchanges. At

present, timing differences in the inclusion or removal of stocks from the derivatives segment could create a gap of a few trading days. For instance, if the NSE adds a stock to F&O on Wednesday, that stock immediately shifts to dynamic price bands on the NSE. But on the BSE, the same stock may remain under fixed 20 per cent price bands until Friday, when its derivatives contracts begin. In the reverse case, the mismatch could stretch from Friday to Tuesday, depending on which exchange acts first. The same problem arises when a stock is removed from derivatives trading. If the NSE removes it on Wednesday, the stock reverts to



fixed price bands there immediately, while the BSE may continue treating it as a derivatives stock until Friday. The people said SEBI sees this as a regulatory gap that needs to be addressed.

DYNAMIC BANDS “The proposal aims to eliminate temporary mismatches during entry and exit phases, ensure uniform trading conditions, and prevent price

distortions,” one of the sources said. Dynamic price bands allow price movement to widen step by step, usually beginning at 10 per cent, then expanding to 15 per cent and 20 per cent, with further relaxations possible in strong market conditions. Fixed bands, by contrast, typically cap movement at 20 per cent in a day. When one exchange applies dynamic bands and another imposes fixed limits on the same stock, this could create a distorted trading picture, open up arbitrage opportunities and confuse investors, market participants said. SEBI is expected to come out with a circular on the same soon.

The great un-bundling: How maturing Indian markets are shrugging off concentration

RINGSIDE
VIEW.



KS BADRI NARAYANAN

The National Stock Exchange's latest ‘Market Pulse’ report from April offers an interesting comparative study, benchmarking global markets and revealing the key structural shifts in Indian markets that are driving greater maturity and resilience. According to the report, over the past three decades, global markets have undergone a marked shift in sectoral composition. For instance, the US markets have seen a sharp rise in technology dominance, while China has transitioned from a real estate-led model to a balanced mix of technology and financials. On the other hand, Japan's market structure has remained relatively stable, with gradual diversification. **FINANCIALS DOMINATE** “India's transition has been distinct: From a commodity-

led market to one increasingly dominated by financials, alongside a declining share of materials and energy. These shifts are reflected in rising concentration levels in the US markets, whereas India has moved in the opposite direction, with declining concentration indicating broader dispersion across firms and sectors,” according to the study. In 1995, materials dominated with a 25 per cent share of total market capitalisation, followed by energy at 18 per cent and consumer discretionary at 13 per cent. By 2025, the financial sector emerged as the leading sector, accounting for 25 per cent of overall market capitalisation. Industrial and consumer discretionary follow with shares of 13 per cent and 12 per cent, respectively. Notably, the share of information technology has increased significantly to 8 per cent in 2025, compared to 1 per cent in 1995, the report further said. However, information technology sector hit a high of 16 per cent in 2000.

EAAA India, MV Electrosys, Yatayat get signal for IPOs

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Three companies — EAAA India Alternatives, an arm of Edelweiss Financial Services, MV Electrosystems and Yatayat Corporation India — have secured SEBI's approval to raise funds through initial public offerings (IPOs), according to an update from the markets regulator on Friday. They filed their preliminary IPO papers between December and January. EAAA India Alternatives is looking to float a ₹1,500-crore IPO. The proposed issue will be entirely an offer-for-sale (OFS) by the Edelweiss Group. MV Electrosystems plans to raise ₹290 crore through its public offering, according

to its DRHP. The IPO is entirely a fresh issue. Proceeds from the fresh issue, worth ₹180 crore, will be used for funding long-term working capital requirements of the company, ₹21 crore for investment in research, design and development activities for new power electronic equipment, and a portion will be used for general corporate purposes. Logistics and transportation services firm Yatayat Corporation India's IPO comprises a fresh issue of up to 77 lakh shares and an OFS of up to 56 lakh equity shares by a promoter, the draft papers showed. Proceeds from the fresh issue are proposed to be utilised towards meeting working capital requirements and general corporate purposes.

Sector-wise market capitalisation in India (1995-2025) (% share)

	1995	2000	2005	2010	2015	2020	2025
Materials	25	10	12	13	10	11	11
Healthcare	3	6	5	4	9	7	6
Financials	10	6	11	14	16	23	25
Cons. staples	11	17	8	6	10	11	7
Industrials	11	6	9	7	12	9	12
Cons. discretionary	13	6	9	7	12	9	12
Real estate	2	1	1	2	1	1	2
Comm. services	6	9	5	4	5	3	4
IT	1	25	13	10	12	14	8
Energy	18	14	19	16	11	10	7
Utilities	1	2	7	8	4	4	4

Source: LSEG Workspace, NSE EPR

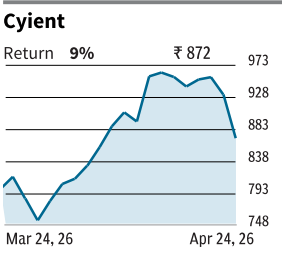
OWNERSHIP CHANGES While the NSE report captures evolving sectoral dominance, a separate study by Prime Database highlights a decline in the long-standing dominance of foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) in Indian markets. FPI holdings, which peaked at 25.72 per cent in March 2023, fell sharply to a 13-year low of 16.6 per cent as of December 31, 2025. In contrast, mutual fund holdings touched a record 11.1 per cent, while domestic institutional investors (including DMFs) hit a new peak of 18.72 per

cent. According to the NSE study, FPI holdings increased in communication services and energy, while most sectors saw either stable or declining foreign share in the respective sector's market capitalisation. Communication services recorded a 25-quarter high of 23.7 per cent, while the energy sector recorded a five-quarter high of 16.7 per cent. Consumer discretionary and financials witnessed the sharpest declines, with FPI share falling to 15.9 per cent (a 14-quarter low) and 23.4 per cent (near a 21-year low), respectively.

Cyient slides 6.8% on Q4 miss; buyback at premium offers limits cushion

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shares of Cyient fell sharply on Friday, down 6.72 per cent to ₹873.05, after the engineering services company reported a steep sequential and year-on-year decline in quarterly profit. The stock opened at ₹937 and slid to a low of ₹867.05 on the NSE. The company's Q4 consolidated net profit came in at ₹54.80 crore, down sharply from ₹91.8 crore in the previous quarter, while revenue rose to ₹1,930 crore from ₹1,850 crore.. **BROKERS' VIEWS** The numbers were tagged neutral by the Street but the



profit miss weighed on sentiment. Morgan Stanley maintained an ‘Underweight’ rating with a target of ₹1,050, noting that while transportation and mobility performed ahead of expectations, the decline in strategic units was sharper than estimated. It acknowledged that the buyback could lend some support and that the stock trades cheap, but said that

investors would want to see consistent growth in the DET business before turning constructive. Choice International retained a medium-term constructive view with a sum-of-the-parts target price of ₹1,250 based on FY28 estimates, citing stable margins and improving order intake. It noted that the buyback at ₹1,125 per share — roughly 20 per cent above Friday's trading price — is EPS-accretive and supportive of sentiment, though it has not yet been factored into estimates pending clarity on acceptance ratios. The board-approved buyback covers up to 64 lakh shares worth ₹720 crore via tender offer, with promoters opting out entirely.

Nifty 50 Movers ▼ 275.10 pts.

	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN%
State Bank	1101.10	6.20	11.75	4.17
Coal India	456.00	2.65	9.44	0.95
Trent Ltd.	4297.30	2.22	88.75	0.87
Hindalco	1048.35	2.21	14.65	1.39
Bajaj Finance	921.55	1.87	31.29	2.25
NestleIndia	1421.30	1.69	78.33	0.93
HDFC Bank	784.85	1.67	15.25	10.97
Kotak Bank	370.85	0.72	19.62	2.49
Bajaj Auto	9576.00	0.62	30.13	0.97
Shriram Finance Ltd.	101.30	0.61	20.80	0.80
Eicher Motors	7111.50	0.57	36.41	0.99
Grasim Ind	2739.30	0.36	19.68	0.95
JSW Steel	1255.70	-0.27	39.54	1.07
NTPC	401.85	-0.41	15.69	1.74
Tata Motors PV	350.50	-0.66	47.66	0.67
Adani Enter	2287.60	-0.70	18.68	0.54
Apollo Hosp	7732.50	-1.09	59.59	0.73
Max Healthcare	999.40	-1.19	68.53	0.68
ONGC	284.80	-1.23	7.97	1.01
Cipla	1295.00	-1.34	23.08	0.67
TataConsumerProduct	1174.00	-1.48	78.95	0.70
Tata Steel	210.07	-1.51	28.75	1.59
Int'lDevel	453.10	-1.62	54.03	0.58
M&M	3038.40	-1.81	22.35	2.48
Dr Reddys Lab	1317.10	-1.85	19.90	0.73
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	245.73	-2.10	100.02	0.74
Wipro	199.36	-2.12	15.76	0.52
Axis Bank	1365.90	-2.32	16.07	3.58
HDFC Life	588.20	-2.45	67.14	0.58
PowerGrid Corp	316.40	-2.72	18.96	1.31
Bajaj Finserv	1770.70	-2.76	14.76	0.93
Adani Ports	1585.10	-2.86	29.22	1.07
Maruti Suzuki	13048.00	-3.21	27.47	1.56
Asian Paints	2485.10	-3.58	60.96	1.03
Titan	4410.00	-4.19	82.15	1.66
Bharti Elec	444.45	-4.30	54.45	1.40
UltraTech Cement	11998.00	-4.37	46.14	1.30
Eternal Ltd.	256.79	-4.92	1072.78	1.69
SBI Life	1768.90	-5.80	71.56	0.73
Hind Unilever	2327.30	-7.57	54.38	1.89
ITC	301.60	-7.78	18.25	2.65
Tech Mahindra	1358.50	-8.73	37.12	0.79
L&T	4014.30	-10.19	29.10	4.30
Sun Pharma	1620.40	-13.79	35.50	1.57
HCL Tech	1203.20	-17.13	19.61	1.16
Bharti Airtel	1814.50	-17.88	29.84	5.08
Reliance Ind	1327.80	-22.99	18.38	8.19
ICSI	2396.90	-27.83	17.54	2.23
ICI Bank	1236.20	-34.00	18.57	0.94
Infosys	1154.60	-65.78	16.72	3.70

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers ▼ 526.40 pts.

	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN%
Adani Energy Solutions .	1411.95	49.65	71.15	1.98
Cholamandalam&Fin	1568.20	29.98	27.56	2.71
Varun Beverages .	490.45	23.95	54.17	2.71
Tata Power .	435.20	22.21	27.75	2.94
Cummins India	5232.00	21.01	64.69	2.85
AdaniGreenenergy	1235.80	20.49	109.68	1.67
Britannia Ind	5730.50	19.62	57.12	2.73
Hdfc Amc	2735.00	15.41	41.00	2.25
United Spirits .	1391.90	8.00	58.86	1.66
Sail India .	1455.61	4.95	12.65	1.80
Punjab Natl Bank	113.09	3.70	7.27	1.58
Jindal Steel	1256.00	1.57	63.55	1.88
Ambuja Cements	451.20	1.38	22.66	1.11
Canara Bank	140.85	-0.19	6.94	1.92
Power Finance	469.35	-1.85	4.64	2.76
Magazgan Dock	2680.40	-2.87	44.93	0.82
Siemens Energy India .	3205.10	-4.12	96.62	1.15
Tata Capital	337.20	-4.15	31.35	0.59
Hindus Zinc	588.50	-4.41	21.07	1.03
Divis Lab	6361.50	-6.10	68.12	3.27
Indian Railway Finance Corp	103.92	-6.47	19.38	0.84
Piplitind	1394.30	-6.83	61.32	1.75
Rural Elec	374.00	-8.54	5.71	1.89
Torrent Pharma	4017.20	-8.68	61.33	1.74
Bpcl	308.10	-9.73	5.43	2.52
Indian Hotels Co .	635.35	-10.16	41.78	2.25
DIF	587.05	-10.41	32.81	1.52
Bank Of Baroda	274.13	-11.57	7.22	2.05
MacroTech Developers .	840.70	-12.56	25.10	0.96
ZydusLifeSciences	977.40	-13.01	16.37	0.96
Siemens	3808.90	-13.85	85.55	1.35
Bajaj Holdings	10259.50	-14.30	12.74	1.79
Union Bank	177.00	-14.78	7.13	1.38
Adani Power .	212.90	-14.95	36.34	3.56
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3488.20	-16.44	54.27	3.31
Bosch	3669.00	-16.89	39.25	1.29
Samvardnathersoninternatl	125.70	-18.99	36.45	2.25
Shree Cement	24950.00	-19.63	50.12	1.35
Muthoot	3493.50	-20.56	16.21	1.51
Indian Oilcorp	143.47	-21.20	5.00	2.17
Hyundai Motor India .	1783.60	-24.39	25.03	1.03
Cg Power & Ind Sol	423.15	-28.34	118.85	2.28
AvenueSuper	744.50	-32.29	100.95	2.64
Abd India	4428.50	-36.57	92.09	1.55
Tata Motors Cv	424.55	-43.07	94.94	3.58
Hindustanaeronautics	4255.80	-46.43	32.07	3.27
Solar Industries	15056.00	-47.52	89.24	1.48
Godrej Consumer	1089.90	-40.24	61.22	1.77
Luminidee	4382.30	-65.26	26.80	1.61
Vedanta	720.95	-70.27	17.01	4.95

Pts: Impact on index movement

Job well done

Cook's era at Apple was defined by operational excellence

Tim Cook's legacy at Apple is best understood not in comparison to Steve Jobs, but as a redefinition of what leadership after a founder leaves looks like. He did not replicate Jobs' product genius. Instead, he built one of the most formidable corporate machines in history. Under Cook, Apple transformed itself from a company dependent on breakthrough hits into a highly predictable, cash-generating ecosystem. Revenues multiplied, margins strengthened, and the company's market value climbed into the trillions.

Yet the critique of Cook is equally consistent. Apple, many argue, became more disciplined but less daring. There was no single product moment to rival the iPhone. Innovations such as the Watch, AirPods, and Apple Silicon deepened the ecosystem, rather than redefine it. Big bets like the Apple Car never materialised, and in emerging areas such as artificial intelligence, the tech major has appeared cautious, even slow, compared to rivals like Google and Microsoft. Nowhere is Cook's long-game strategy clearer than in India. Once a marginal market, India has, under his tenure, become central to Apple's future. The company has steadily built a premium consumer base, even as its overall market share remains modest. More significantly, India has emerged as a critical manufacturing hub, reflecting Apple's effort to diversify beyond China and de-risk its supply chain. Retail expansion, local production, and a growing installed base together signal a structural shift: Apple is embedding itself within India's economic trajectory.

The transition to the new CEO, John Ternus, a hardware-focused insider, marks a subtle but important pivot. If Cook's era was defined by operational excellence and ecosystem expansion, the next phase will likely revive Steve Jobs' era with a strong emphasis on product reinvention. The challenge for Apple under Ternus will be to find its "next iPhone moment" in a world already saturated with devices. At the same time, it must navigate geopolitical tensions, supply chain shifts, and rising regulatory scrutiny.

Apple's relative restraint in the AI race, often seen as a weakness, could yet prove strategic. Unlike competitors whose business models depend on data extraction and advertising, Apple has the structural advantage of prioritising user privacy. Its emphasis on on-device processing and tightly integrated hardware-software systems positions it to develop AI that is less intrusive and more user-controlled. But leadership in what might be called "AI for good" will require more than branding. It will demand verifiable privacy standards, data minimisation, transparent systems, and a willingness to prioritise trust over rapid monetisation. This may come at the cost of being first or even best in raw capability. Yet, as regulatory pressures mount and public awareness grows, trust could become the defining currency of the AI era. Cook's tenure, in hindsight, may come to be seen not as an era of missed invention, but as one of strategic preparation.

POCKET



Are freebies really a curse?

THE BENEFITS. Direct cash handouts score over capex in raising demand for goods and services. They empower women



MADAN SABNAVIS

The recent State Assembly elections have once again seen announcements of cash transfers, which has attracted the attention of economists. Such giveaways, or freebies, are considered a drain on the State exchequer. But, is there another side to this issue which we are missing?

Unlike the Centre, States are bound by fiscal deficit norms, usually 3-3.5 per cent of GDP. If this is higher at the time of announcement of their respective Budgets, States would have to seek the Centre or the RBI's permission. Therefore, it is hard to say that overall fiscal ratios are inevitably breached by such expenditures.

Second, cash transfers in the form of direct payments or subsidies are implemented by both the Centre and States. In fact, the Centre has a larger budget and deficit ratio relative to States and hence can provide greater support through centrally sponsored schemes which involve food subsidy, cash payments to farmers, employment programmes, among others.

CAPEX TRADE-OFF

Third, critics bring up the trade-off between capex and revenue expenditure. Freebies are considered non-productive while capex generates future output by forging strong backward linkages with industries involved in supplying inputs.

Arguably, cash transfers are not really unproductive as the cash given is usually spent, since it is usually dispensed to the lower income groups. This adds to the consumption chain and drives the demand for goods and services.

A significant part of rural demand, which has supported growth in the consumer goods industry, can be attributed to such transfers. States also often give sewing machines, cycles, laptops to womenfolk, which spur demand in the industries concerned — just as construction of a road adds to demand for steel and cement.

EMPOWERING WOMEN

Fourth, cash transfers are supposed to create a moral hazard, affecting the incentive to work. This argument may be weak because it has been seen that cash handouts to women help them to run their households.



INCOME BOOST. Direct cash transfers benefit the target group by freeing expenditure on other goods THANGARATHINAM N

Further, free transport for girls and women empower them as it helps them attend school and commute to their place of work. Free transport prevents school dropouts especially in rural households. In rural areas, especially in the lower income groups, households do not want to invest in education for girls. Free transport enables such empowerment.

Fifth, the Centre runs a free food scheme which costs ₹2 lakh crore. This game-changing scheme has provided

Cash transfers are definitely a step in providing a basic income especially for low-income households. This is also a way of bringing about redistributive justice in a country with considerable income inequality

access to food and freed up money that can be spent on other goods and services.

The free food scheme has helped people rise above the poverty line. It has also spurred a shift in consumption pattern from food to non-food items, which is revealed in the household consumption expenditure survey (also used for recalibrating the CPI index).

Sixth, the Centre has been running the rural employment scheme for over two decades with outlays of ₹80,000 crore to ₹1 lakh crore on an annual basis. The idea of the MGNREGA programme was to provide some employment to the farmers during the off-season. The high funds utilisation of the scheme is a pointer to the lack of job opportunities in rural areas.

The demand also perhaps shows that the trickle down approach, which is theoretically supposed to unfold as the economy grows, has not worked in the desired manner in the farm sector.

Seventh, direct cash transfers to targeted people are more beneficial than

India must lead on social media curbs for kids

Big tech cannot be allowed to function without guardrails. Children must be protected against the excesses of social media

Ajal Chowdhry

Nobody usually phrases it this way, but technology is almost a humanities discipline. We are creating systems that reflect, shape, and augment the human experience.

In recent years, with the deep and pervasive penetration of digital technologies — from algorithm-driven platforms to generative AI — technology has moved centre stage in our lives. At the heart of this shift sits social media —widely used for networking, sharing and socialising — but beneath its benefits lies a troubling underside of addiction, manipulation and mental health risks. Its impact on children must be taken with urgency.

Platforms such as Instagram, Meta, X (formerly Twitter), TikTok and YouTube, are not neutral tools. They are engineered for compulsion. Infinite scrolling, autoplay, algorithmic nudges is the way such tech is designed. For minors, the harm lies not just in what they see, but in how long they are made to stay. This is not entertainment; it is behavioural conditioning.

The consequences are visible. The US Surgeon General has called for cigarette-style warning labels on social media platforms, signalling a public

health concern. Some years ago, the suicide of Canadian teenager Amanda Todd following sextortion and cyber bullying had sparked outrage. Many young social media users fall easy prey to predators on the prowl. Apart from such crimes, unhinged social media use gets addictive.

NYU social psychologist Jonathan Haidt, in *The Anxious Generation*, draws a direct link between the rise in youth anxiety and depression and the advent of phone-based social media apps. Average daily screen time for teenagers now ranges between 8-10 hours, excluding schoolwork.

This is not merely a social issue. To be future-ready is to be adaptive, thoughtful, and capable of deep work. Children conditioned to constant digital stimulation may lose the power for creative thinking. At the same time, a child cannot meaningfully consent to a system designed to override self-control.

Globally, governments are beginning to respond. Australia implemented a nationwide ban on social media for children under 16 in late 2025. Indonesia followed in March 2026, restricting minors under 16 from accessing major platforms such as YouTube, TikTok, Instagram, Facebook and X. Across Europe, countries like Denmark and



SOCIAL MEDIA. Addiction worries

France are debating or moving towards similar age-based restrictions. Even in the US, there is growing momentum for tighter controls.

INDIAN IMPERATIVES

In India, the conversation has begun but remains fragmented. Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh have proposed restrictions for minors, sparking debate on implementation and parental responsibility. But piecemeal responses are not enough.

India, with over 54 per cent of its population below the age of 25, cannot afford to treat this lightly. The country's future — its workforce and its innovation capacity — depends on how this generation develops. We have

demonstrated global leadership in building digital public infrastructure, from UPI to DigiYatra and DigiLocker, creating systems that combine scale with trust. That same leadership must now extend to digital well-being.

The argument against regulation often frames such bans as excessive or impractical. But every major industry —from telecom to banking — operates within guardrails. Why should Big Tech be the exception? The government must step in to working with Big Tech to put guardrails as they need to take the responsibility.

If minors are to be protected, platforms must be made accountable. Anyone joining social media must show proof of age. This is not about stifling innovation but about aligning it with societal interest. Also, the responsibility must be shared. Parents, schools, and policymakers need to take action at the right time. Digital literacy must include not just how to use technology, but how to resist its excesses.

We owe our children a childhood lived in the moment — curious, open, and unhurried — not one surrendered to the algorithmic appetites of Big Tech.

The writer is Chairman, EPIC Foundation and MGB (Mission Governing Board), National Quantum Mission. Views expressed are personal

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Women lawmakers

This refers to the article 'Women as lawmakers'. India has made notable progress in various sectors, yet the representation of women in legislative bodies remains relatively low. Increasing women's participation in lawmaking is not merely a matter of equality but it is a strategic economic decision. It has been proved that women leaders tend to prioritize issues such as education, healthcare, nutrition, and social welfare, sectors that are crucial for social and economic development. Women lawmakers are also more likely to advocate for inclusive policies that support small businesses, SHGs, and

entrepreneurship, particularly among rural and marginalized communities. Empowering women in legislative roles is not just a social reform but it is an economic imperative.

Bal Govind
Noida

IPO blues

With reference to the Editorial "Misreading markets" (April 24), the market impact of the significant decline in the IPOs of the companies due to war is noteworthy, considering the substantial cost of launching the offerings involved. In majority of the issues floated in the recent past, promoters and

external investors made exits from investments at superfluous valuations causing colossal losses to the retail investors, due to poor price sustainability post listing of the shares. The current situation has hit the fund raising plans of companies, especially SMEs, it has also insulated retail investors from losses. Regulatory norms permitting extension of launching timelines and reduction in offer size for already approved offers, is a great respite to companies, which would save time involved in preparation of new offer documents and additional disclosures.

Sitaram Popuri
Bengaluru

'Spread' dynamics

It is with reference to the article 'Spreads are crucial to oil prices' (April 24). Spreads are indeed crucial for oil prices and act as key market indicators that reflect supply/demand dynamics, storage constraints and refined product demand. Crack spread is the price difference between crude oil and its refined products. If crack spreads are high, refiners run at capacity to make products driving up demand for crude. Ultimately, spreads provide a more accurate picture of physical market tightness than the speculative flat price of crude.

P Victor Selvaraj
Palayamkottai (TN)

Mother Dairy's success

Apropos 'Mother Dairy crosses ₹20k cr turnover milestone, eyes 20% growth' (April 23). Being a subsidiary of NDDB, a govt of India enterprise, this achievement is truly remarkable. With 20 per cent growth as target, it would be ideal if farmers are offered a chunk of profits as an incentive for their contribution to companies growth and success. KMF must take a cue from this growth story and encourage more farmers to take up dairying.

Rajiv Magal
Halekere Village (Karnataka)



QUICKLY.

RBI's penalty on Bandhan Bank, Muthoot Housing

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank (RBI) said it has imposed ₹41.8 lakh penalty on Bandhan Bank for non-compliance with certain norms, including directions on 'know your customer'. While imposing penalty on Bandhan Bank, the RBI said the bank failed to carry out periodic review of risk categorisation of certain categories of accounts, and had sanctioned director-related loans. The central bank also slapped penalty of ₹80,000 on Muthoot Housing Finance Company for non-compliance with certain directions issued by the RBI on 'Fair Practice Code'. [PTI](#)

SBI General profit up 9 per cent in FY26

New Delhi: SBI General Insurance on Friday reported an 8.6 per cent rise in net profit to ₹553 crore for the financial year ended March 2026. The non-life subsidiary of the State Bank of India recorded net profit of ₹509 crore in the preceding financial year. In terms of financial position, the company's solvency ratio stood at 1.9 times, well above the regulatory requirement, highlighting its strong capital position, SBI General Insurance said in a statement. [PTI](#)

DCB Bank Q4 net profit rises 16% to ₹206 crore



New Delhi: Private sector lender DCB Bank reported a 16 per cent increase in net profit to ₹206 crore for the fourth quarter ended March 2026. The bank reported a net profit of ₹177 crore in the year-ago period. The total income rose to ₹2,119 crore in the January-March quarter of the FY26 from ₹1,961 crore in the year-ago period. [PTI](#)

Mahindra Finance fourth quarter profit jumps 55%

Amit Vijay Mohile

Mumbai
Mahindra Finance on Friday reported a 55 per cent year-on-year jump in profit after tax (PAT) for the March quarter, driven by margin expansion and steady asset quality, even as credit costs inched up.
Standalone PAT for Q4 FY26 rose to ₹873 crore from ₹563 crore a year earlier. Disbursements grew 11 per cent to ₹17,184 crore, while assets under management (AUM) increased 12 per cent to ₹1.34 lakh crore.
Net interest margins expanded by about 101 basis points to 7.5 per cent, reflecting improved yields.

CREDIT COST

For the full year FY26, PAT rose 19 per cent to ₹2,782 crore, supported by higher margins and operating leverage, even as credit costs rose to 1.7 per cent following management overlays.
Asset quality remained within guidance, with gross stage 3 assets at 3.4 per cent and stage 2 and 3 assets at 8.2 per cent. The board has proposed a final dividend of ₹7.50 per share, up from ₹6.50 last year.
“This year’s progress across growth, margins and risk was driven by disciplined execution and resulted in a tangible step-up in profitability,” said Raul Rebello, MD & CEO, Mahindra Finance. He added that continued investments in the core vehicle financing franchise, new growth categories and technology will support sustainable growth.
The company is accelerating diversification beyond its core vehicle finance business, with the non-vehicle portfolio growing 32 per cent year-on-year, led by SME lending and loan-against-property products.

IIT-Ropar launches India’s 1st fully integrated agri intelligence system

PRECISION ADVISORIES. Advanced weather stations, Krishi intelligence call centres to offer AI-driven insights

Subramani Ra Mancombu

Chennai
The Indian Institute of Technology, Ropar, has launched an agricultural intelligence ecosystem, comprising advanced weather stations called Swan, Krishi intelligence call centres and Annam chat engine (ACE).

The ecosystem is scalable and is India’s first fully-integrated agricultural intelligence system. It has been launched by the institution’s Centre of Excellence (CoE) in AI for Agriculture, ANNAM.AI, Project Director Pushpendra P Singh told *businessline*.
“The intelligence ecosystem is designed to support the entire agricultural value chain,” he said. It integrates, apart from AI, Internet of Things (IoT), climate science and multilingual advisory systems into one integrated ecosystem.
“It offers AI-driven insights, precision advisories, hyperlocal climate intelli-



Pushpendra P Singh, Project Director, Centre of Excellence in AI for Agriculture, IIT-Ropar

gence and crop diagnostics all in one platform,” said Singh.

THREE LAYERS

The AI architecture has three layers. One is the infrastructure layer. It comprises micro-climate intelligence units and advanced weather stations that capture field-level data, temperature, humidity, wind and rainfall.
It enables precise irrigation, pest prediction and risk mitigation. Second is the intelligence layer, Krishi AI,

which uses computer vision and analytics to identify crops, detect pests and assess damage, turning raw data into predictive intelligence. The third is the engagement layer, where the Annam chat engine delivers multilingual, expert-validated advisories directly to farmers, covering weather alerts, crop planning, pest management and market trends.
The system is up and running on the ground. “Instead of waiting for a single cere-

monial launch, we chose a phased rollout so farmers could start benefiting immediately,” he said.
The Centre of Excellence at IIT-Ropar was established under the government’s ₹990 crore national initiative to create three AI Centres of Excellence, including one dedicated to agriculture at Ropar. “This positions ANNAM.AI as a flagship, government-backed programme with a mandate to build largescale digital public infrastructure for farming,” said Singh.

GAINS FOR FARMERS

By mid-2026, AI-powered weather stations, micro-climate intelligence units and advisory systems have begun operating in Punjab. The platform is now generating real-time insights for farmers in pilot regions, with a clear roadmap for pan-India expansion.
“ANNAM.AI will redefine climate-smart farming for the next decade,” he said. Gains for farmers will be

significant and measurable from these initiatives. With hyperlocal weather intelligence and AI-based advisories, farmers can reduce water usage by 20-30 per cent, avoid unnecessary pesticide use and prevent 9-12 per cent of crop loss caused by sudden weather events.
“Even a small reduction in climate-related losses translates into meaningful financial savings. Over time, we help farmers improve productivity, reduce risks and make confident, data-driven decisions, leading to more stable and sustainable incomes,” said Singh.
On how ANNAM.AI prepared for this, he said it required a blend of deep research, field validation and national-scale engineering. IIT-Ropar focused on designing technology that works in real conditions, not just controlled labs. It ensured the platform is farmer-friendly, multilingual and accessible, and built systems that function even in low-connectivity rural areas.

IGC pares global grain output projections for 2026-27 by 3 mt



RECORD HARVEST. The council said total grain production is expected to reach a new peak in 2025/26 at 2,474 million tonnes, 6 per cent higher than the previous year

Our Bureau

Bengaluru

The International Grains Council (IGC) has lowered its global foodgrain production projections for 2026-27 by 3 million tonnes (mt) from its earlier estimate on concerns over fertilizer affordability due to the ongoing war in West Asia disrupting the supply chain.

In its latest April estimates, the IGC projected that grain output will be 2,414 mt compared to its earlier projection of 2,417 mt on an anticipated decline in production of all major crops, including wheat and maize.
“Concerns about fertilizer affordability and application decisions have added to uncertainties about the 2026-27 cropping outlook, including in parts of the southern hemisphere, where upcoming requirements may not be fully covered,” the IGC said in its latest grain market report.

2ND LARGEST EVER

“Although some projections have been trimmed month-on-month, with the total down by 3 million tonnes, the global out-turn is still anticipated to be the second

largest ever, at 2,414 million tonnes. Compared to last month’s initial outlook, the consumption estimate is lowered, with forecast inventories higher and trade unchanged,” it said.
Consumption is pegged 3 mt lower at 2,437 mt compared to the initial estimate.
The council said total grain production is expected to reach a new peak in 2025/26 at 2,474 mt — 6 per cent higher than the previous year.
With comparatively slower growth in consumption (+3 per cent), global stocks are forecast to build by 9 per cent, marking the sharpest rate of expansion in nine years. Trade is pegged 6 per cent higher than the previous season, at 451 mt, including increases for most grains, it said.
At 2,414 mt, the world output is projected to remain elevated in 2026/27. However, with anticipated declines for all major crops, including wheat and maize, the total is seen 2 per cent short of the prior year’s record.
With a high level of carry-in stocks offering only partial offsetting, total supply is forecast to be slightly tighter compared to the prior season.

Amazon in pact with Bayer’s TGRA for rice carbon credits

Our Bureau

Bengaluru

The Good Rice Alliance (TGRA) has entered into a long term off-take agreement with Amazon for sale of carbon credits generated from its sustainable rice farming initiative in India, which is focused on reducing methane emissions.
TGRA, which is focused on advancing sustainable rice farming in India, is implementing a major project for reducing methane emissions from rice cultivation among more than 13,000 small farmers across 35,000 hectares in multiple States.
Amazon is collaborating with TGRA as the primary

buyer for the project, with its commitment covering more than 6,85,000 metric tonnes of Co2 equivalent carbon credits during the initial crediting phase, according to a TGRA statement.

SCALABLE SOLUTIONS

This role highlights Amazon’s dedication to advancing scalable solutions for climate impact and illustrates the substantial reach of TGRA’s initiative.
TGRA, a company owned by Bayer, builds on a multi-year feasibility study and pilot programme undertaken by Bayer, GenZero and Shell Nature-Based Solutions, which established the technical, scientific and operational foundations for

largescale rice methane mitigation. GenZero’s and Shell’s participation in the long-term programme remain subject to applicable regulatory approvals.
The agreement with Amazon supports TGRA’s largescale programme working with smallholder rice farmers to reduce methane emissions through the adoption of improved water-management practices, including alternate wetting and drying and direct seeded rice.
Methane is a super pollutant with a global warming potential over 27 times that of carbon dioxide, making near-term reductions critical for slowing climate change this decade.
“This agreement with

Amazon reflects growing demand for rigorously measured, high-integrity methane mitigation credits,” said Suhas Joshi, Director of the Board, TGRA & Carbon Initiative Lead, Bayer South Asia. “Our focus is on delivering real, verifiable climate outcomes while ensuring that smallholder farmers are at the centre of the value created.”

METHANE EMISSIONS

Conventional rice cultivation, which involves the continuous flooding of paddy fields, accounts for 8-10 per cent of global methane emissions, making it the second largest source of agricultural methane emissions globally, behind livestock.

Geographically, India is the third largest global methane emitter with the largest area of rice cultivation in the world, which supports over 100 million livelihoods, the statement said.
“Methane is a super pollutant that demands our attention now, and agriculture represents a critical opportunity to reduce emissions,” said Michelle Jolly, Director of Sustainability Solutions and Services at Amazon. “We’re supporting a programme that delivers measurable emissions reductions at scale while helping thousands of farmers build more water-efficient operations. It’s the kind of practical solution that moves us from ambition to real impact.”

India releases second phase of flight training rankings

Our Bureau

New Delhi

India on Friday released the second phase of rankings for Flying Training Organisations (FTOs).
According to the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA), the FTO ranking system, compiled by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), is aimed at strengthening training standards, enhancing safety and promoting accountability across flying training institutions.
The first phase of the rankings was published on October 1, 2025. Notably, the Ministry said the data-driven

framework enables objective comparison and continuous monitoring of FTO performance, while improving transparency across the pilot training ecosystem.
“My core objective in introducing an FTO ranking system in the country is to make pilot training more transparent and flying a more attractive career option for the youth,” Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu said during the launch event.
Highlighting opportunities in the sector, Naidu said, “In the next five years, India’s aviation landscape will expand with 50 more airports, Indian carriers inducting around 500 more aircraft

and major Indian airports evolving into transit hubs through our Hub and Spoke Policy.”
HISTORIC OUTLAY
“Additionally, with the historic outlay of ₹29,000 crore under modified UDAN, there is significant scope for regional connectivity. There is an estimated requirement of nearly 30,000 additional pilots over the next decade.”
According to MoCA, the Indian aviation training ecosystem has recorded several positive developments, including an increase in training flying hours from 32 per cent to 50 per cent, expansion of aircraft fleet at FTOs and improved training effi-

ciency, reducing the time required by cadets to complete flying requirements for obtaining a commercial pilot licence. Besides, the Ministry said the ranking system enabled aspiring pilots to make informed decisions based on objective performance indicators.
“The broader objective is two-fold. First, to enhance the global competitiveness of Indian FTOs by encouraging alignment with international benchmarks. Second, to promote self-reliance in pilot training

through a ‘Train in India, Fly in India’ approach,” Naidu said.
He added that six new FTOs had been approved over the last 18 months, while six more are currently in the pipeline.
As per the April 2026 rankings, one FTO qualified in Category ‘A’, compared with none in the previous phase.
The number of FTOs in Category ‘C’ declined, while Category ‘B’ institutions increased, indicating an overall improvement in performance standards.



Kerala Co-operative Milk Marketing Federation Ltd.
Milma Bhavan, Pattom P.O, Thiruvananthapuram - 695004
Ph: 0471 2786436 & 424, E-mail: marketing@milma.com

Tender for Custom Packing of Ready to Drink Palada Payasam

Bid reference :	KCMMF/HO/MMG/10/2026 C (Tender ID-2026_KCMMF_847912_1)
Name of work :	Tender invited for the Production, Packaging and Supply of Ready to Drink Palada Payasam.
Last Date for submission:	16.05.2026. Detailed tender notice available in our website www.milma.com
Contact for more details	- 9847261722
Sd/-	MANAGING DIRECTOR



TATA POWER
The Tata Power Company Limited
(Mundra Thermal Power Station - UMPP)
Tunda Vandi Road, Tunda Village, Mundra, Kutch, Gujarat
Reg. Office: Bombay House, 24 Horni Modi Street, Mumbai – 400 001

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

The Tata Power Company Limited invites tender from eligible vendors for the following tender package (Two-part Bidding).
(A) **Corrigendum 1_NIT_Package A:** EPC Package (Without Civil) for replacement of 245 kV GIS at Salsette receiving station And Package B: EPC Package (Without Civil) for Installation of new 220 kV Outdoor GIS Substation at Powal receiving Station. (**Package Ref: CC26AM011**).
Interested & eligible bidders for above packages to submit Tender Fee, Authorization Letter before **1500 hrs. Thursday, 30th April, 2026.**
<https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website **Tata Power Business Associates Tender Documents**) only



Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation

Request For Proposal (RFP) for Selection of Agency for supply of Human Resources at various veterinary hospitals under Veterinary Department of Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation

Tender No. 01/2026-27

Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation (PCMC) hereby invites ‘Selection of Agency for supply of Human Resources at various veterinary hospitals under Veterinary Department of Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation’. Bidders are advised to study this RFP document carefully before submitting their proposals in response to this RFP Notice. Submission of a proposal in response to this notice shall be deemed to have been carried out after careful study and examination of this document with full understanding of its terms, conditions, and implications.
Interested Bidders are requested to download the RFP document published on **eProcurement System Government of Maharashtra** from 25/04/2026. The last date for bid submission 07/05/2026 by 3:00 PM. The downloaded bidding document shall be considered valid for participation in the electronic bidding process (e-Tendering) subject to the payment of RFP Fee. For any type of clarifications, Bidders can visit www.mahatenders.gov.in or contact help desk contact no. 0120-4001 462, 0120-4001 002, 0120-4001 005, 0120-6277 787, **Email: support-eproc@nic.in**

Name of Work	Tender Fees (Rs) (Non-Refundable)	EMD (Rs)
Selection of Agency for supply of Human Resources at various veterinary hospitals under Veterinary Department of Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation	Rs. 66,310 (Sixty-Six Thousand Three Hundred and Ten Rupees Only)	Rs 10,76,000 (Ten Lakh and Seventy-Six Thousand Rupees Only)

Commissioner, PCMC reserves the rights to reject any or all applications without assigning any reasons thereof. In this regard his decision will be final and legally binding on all the Bidders.

Sd/-
Commissioner
Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation
Pimpri - 411 018

Advt. No.: [2026-27/26]
Out No. pavai/02/kavi/118/2026
Date: 24/04/2026

QUICKLY.

Crude oil slips as Iran-US peace talks likely



London: Crude oil turned negative on Friday after a Pakistani government source said Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi was expected to arrive in Islamabad on Friday night with a small team and peace talks with the US were likely to take place. By 1203 GMT, Brent crude futures were down 79 cents at \$104.28. US WTI futures fell 95 cents to \$94.90. REUTERS

Copper down as Hormuz stand-off continues

London: Copper prices edged down on worries about the continued closure of the Strait of Hormuz. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME slipped 0.4 per cent to \$13,299 a tonne by 1415 GMT. Nickel advanced 1 per cent to \$18,920, its highest since January 29, on supply woes. The International Nickel Study Group this week said the market was expected to swing to its first annual deficit since 2021. REUTERS

Sugar rebounds after plunging to 5-year lows



Raw sugar futures on ICE rose on Friday, recovering from last week's five-year-low, as dealers set aside concerns over ample supplies. Raw sugar rose 1.6 per cent to 13.82 cents per lb at 1412 GMT. White sugar rose 1.3 per cent to \$433.20 a tonne. REUTERS

Wheat purchase target hiked as farm gate prices rule lower

HELPING HAND. Centre raises procurement threshold to 345 lakh tonnes, relaxes quality norms across major producing States

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The government has initiated measures to support farm gate wheat prices by raising the procurement target to 345 lakh tonnes (lt), up from 303 lt. It relaxed quality norms across major producing States and urged flour millers — key stakeholders in the wheat ecosystem — to procure directly from the market instead of relying on government sales. The decision is seen by experts as more of posturing as raising the target has no meaning when the actual purchases are trailing the year-ago levels and the target looks far away. “The govern-

ment seems to have lately realised the impact on prices with the absence of traders and stockists from the wheat market this year compared to any normal year,” said a flour miller. After the release of the *Annual Wheat Survey Report 2026*, prepared by Agriwatch and commissioned by the Roller Flour Millers’ Federation of India in New Delhi on Friday, Union Food Secretary Sanjeev Chopra said that, at the request of the States, procurement targets had been revised upward: Madhya Pradesh to 100 lt (from 78 lt), Uttar Pradesh to 25 lt (from 10 lt), Bihar to 1.8 lt (from 0.18 lt), Rajasthan to 23.5 lt (from 21 lt), and Uttarakhhand to 0.5 lt (from 0.01 lt).



DIFFERING VIEWS. Per Agriwatch, wheat output in 2025-26 is pegged at 110.65 mt (109.63 mt in 2024-25), while government estimates are higher at 120.21 mt (117.95 mt)

OMSS POLICY He also appealed to the millers to be *aatmanirbhar* in their wheat requirement and not always depend on government sales. However, he said that the open market

sales (OMSS) policy will be released before the new sale season commences from July. “There was stock limit on stockists, traders, millers for the last few years. Despite

that, many traders and stockists purchased wheat at higher than government rates in the hope that prices would rise. Most of the trade people lost money on wheat due to that aggressive buying and this year everyone is cautious despite the report of crop damage,” said the flour miller quoted earlier. According to the Agriwatch report, wheat production in 2025-26 is estimated to be 110.65 million tonnes (mt) against 109.63 mt in 2024-25. According to the government estimate, output in 2025-26 is estimated to be 120.21 million tonnes (mt) against 117.95 mt in 2024-25. **STATE-WISE OUTPUT** On the crop damage report,

Agriwatch’s Nalin Rawal said the wheat crop was so good this year that production could have reached 115.7 mt. But due to the crop damage from unseasonal rain and hailstorms, there was a drop of over 5 mt from the initial assessment, he said. But Navneet Chitlangia, President of RFMFI, said the output could be somewhere around 115-116 mt. The report has pegged wheat production in Uttar Pradesh at 31.43 mt, in Madhya Pradesh at 27.41 mt, in Punjab at 15.38 mt, in Haryana at 10.61 mt and in Rajasthan at 10.15 mt. It said that except Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Punjab, all other States were likely to have higher wheat production. Meanwhile, the wheat

procurement has reached 164.32 lt as of April 23, against 183.49 lt year-ago. Purchase in Punjab was 75.73 lt against 59.20 lt, in Haryana 65.16 lt against 56.64 lt, in Madhya Pradesh 13.19 lt against 54.09 lt, in Uttar Pradesh 4.08 lt against 5.51 lt, in Rajasthan 5.7 lt against 7.84 lt and in Bihar 17,281 tonnes against 9,991 tonnes. Against the minimum support price of ₹2,585/quintal during the 2025-26 crop year (July-June), the all India average mandi price of wheat on April 22 was ₹2,572. But the average farm gate prices on April 22 were ₹2,439 in Uttar Pradesh, ₹2,416 in Madhya Pradesh, ₹2,395 in Gujarat and ₹2,474 in Rajasthan.

Domestic gold firms up as rupee depreciates against \$

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Gold prices increased in the domestic market despite the weak trend in global markets as the rupee continued to depreciate against the dollar. The yellow metal prices were up by ₹420 on Friday to ₹1,51,479 per 10 g against ₹1,51,059 on Thursday. In fact, the precious metal opened weak by ₹395 at ₹1,50,664 but gained ground on a weak rupee. Spot gold price declined 0.2 per cent to \$4,685 per ounce. It has dropped around 3 per cent so far this week. US gold futures for June delivery also eased 0.5 per cent to \$4,700. On the MCX, gold for June delivery was up 0.29 per cent at ₹1,52,206 while the Au-



gust contract was up 0.34 per cent at ₹1,54,799.

CRUDE OIL PRESSURE Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst-Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said gold prices remained highly volatile, trading in a wide range of \$4,655-4,710, as rising crude prices continued to pressure broader asset classes. In the domestic market, gold prices were driven largely by West Asia developments, particularly tensions involving Iran, Israel and the US presence in the Strait of

Hormuz, which kept uncertainty elevated. With conflicting signals and no clear resolution, gold is expected to stay news-driven and volatile, he said. Kaynat Chainwala, AVP Commodity Research, Kotak Securities, said precious metals were being weighed down by a firmer US dollar, rising treasury yields and elevated crude oil prices. The dollar index held firm near \$98.8, embarking on its first weekly gain in three weeks, acting as a persistent drag on precious metals, he said. The hawkish repricing was compounded by Fed Chair nominee Kevin Warsh, who pledged to uphold the Fed’s independence and called for a new framework to address persistent inflation without committing to easing, he added.

‘Agro-forestry will be renamed tree-based farming’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday said the term ‘agro-forestry’ will soon be renamed ‘tree-based farming’ to encourage wider adoption of integrated farming, particularly among smallholders, with the aim of boosting farm incomes. Addressing a regional agriculture conference for the northern States in Lucknow, he emphasised the need to move beyond cereal-centric farming. “Cereal production alone will not raise incomes. Dairy, beekeeping, fisheries and allied activities are equally important,” he said. “We are getting the name of agro-forestry changed to ‘tree-based farming’. When farmers hear ‘forest’, they assume they cannot cut and sell trees,” Chouhan said, underlining the need to make tree cultivation more access-

ible and commercially viable for small and marginal farmers.

FERTILIZER USAGE Citing Uttar Pradesh as an example, Chouhan said fertilizer consumption had touched about 20 lakh tonnes annually in recent years, raising concerns over excessive use. He cautioned that overuse could damage soil health, stressing that balanced fertilizer use, soil conservation and a shift towards organic and natural farming were essential.

REGION-SPECIFIC STRATEGY The Minister also announced a shift in policy approach. Earlier, a single national-level meeting was held twice a year ahead of the kharif and rabi seasons. However, given India’s diversity, this format was inadequate for detailed discussions.



Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan

des, Uttarakhhand and Jammu and Kashmir have made significant contributions in fruits, vegetables and floriculture, he noted.

CLIMATE RESILIENCE Chouhan stressed that quality seeds are the foundation of agriculture, and availability must align with changing climatic conditions. With rising weather uncertainty and the risk of deficient rainfall, he said farming could no longer follow traditional patterns. Instead, crop choices, seed varieties and techniques must adapt to evolving conditions. He urged the States to prepare comprehensive agriculture roadmaps, assuring them of the Centre’s support through scientists, agricultural universities, Krishi Vigyan Kendras and expert institutions. “Without long-term, state-specific goals, ensuring the welfare of both agriculture and farmers will not be possible,” he said.

From 2026, the government will hold zonal conferences across five regions — east, west, north, south and the north-east — to tailor strategies based on soil, climate, cropping patterns and regional challenges, he said. Among the northern States, Punjab and Haryana led the Green Revolution, while Uttar Pradesh now plays a major role in food-grain production. Meanwhile, Himachal Pra-

Export enquiries lift demand for orthodox tea at Kochi sales

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

Widespread export enquiries continue to buoy demand for orthodox tea at the Kochi auctions, leading to improved sales and a drop in unsold quantities. In sale 17, whole leaf varieties ruled firm to dearer, supported by active buying interest from CIS nations and neighbouring countries. Of the 2,73,934 kg of orthodox leaf offered, around 92 per cent was sold. Overall unsold quantities for both orthodox and CTC teas stood at just 9 per cent, according to Forbes, Ewart & Figgis. Anil George, President of the Tea Trade Association of Cochín, said orthodox teas continued to show resilience, backed by consistent demand, evolving trade channels and strong market

absorption. However, plantation conditions remained under strain due to weather vagaries. **MRL COMPLIANCE** Market dynamics are also shifting, with new direct buyers emerging from the EU bloc. N Lakshmanan Chettiar of Golden Hills Estates said Kochi had become a reliable alternative sourcing hub to Sri Lanka, particularly due to South India’s strong compliance with stringent EU norms on maximum residue levels. The CTC dust market opened ₹5-₹7 a kg lower for liquoring teas, and the market remained barely steady as the sale progressed. The offered quantity was 7,07,596 kg, registering sales percentage of 84. The orthodox dust market was firm to dearer with 95 per cent sales out of the offered quantity of 7,800 kg.

‘Organised gold recycling can curb imports, boost economic stability’

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi



Keyur Shah, CEO, Muthoot Exim

Gold demand in the country is expected to remain strong due to its deep cultural and financial relevance, but the way this demand is met will determine its broader economic impact, according to Keyur Shah, CEO of Muthoot Exim. He said organised gold recycling presented a viable solution by converting idle household gold into active domestic supply. This approach could help reduce import dependence, ease pressure on the current account deficit, and address environmental concerns simultaneously. The company recently launched its 100th Muthoot Gold Point facility and has procured nearly five tonnes

of old gold so far. It plans to expand its network to 200 centres in the next 2 years as part of a broader push to formalise gold recycling across the country. **UNUSED GOLD** India holds one of the world’s largest private gold reserves, largely in the form of unused jewellery in house-

In 2025 alone, gold imports were around 630 tonnes, valued at \$58.8 billion

holds. This creates a structural imbalance, where substantial domestic reserves remain untapped even as the country continues to rely heavily on imports. **HIGHER IMPORTS** With domestic production being negligible, India imports nearly 99 per cent of its gold. It is reported that in 2025 alone, gold imports stood at around 630 tonnes, valued at \$58.8 billion. Muthoot Exim has introduced a standardised and transparent mechanism for

buying old gold through its retail network, aiming to bring structure to a traditionally fragmented and informal market. Shah said formalising gold recycling is not merely a business expansion strategy but a necessary shift in managing one of the country’s most valuable assets. By moving transactions into an organised framework, the initiative seeks to align consumer behaviour with national economic priorities while strengthening the domestic gold supply chain. It is estimated that India has nearly 25,000-30,000 tonnes of private gold holdings. Even if one per cent of this gold holding is recycled in an organised manner, it will reduce the annual imports by 25-33 per cent.

Storage in two of three major reservoirs below 50% of capacity: CWC



WATER STRESS. Overall level in the 166 reservoirs has dropped to 40 per cent of the 183.565 BCM capacity

Our Bureau
Chennai

Two-thirds of India’s 166 major reservoirs had storage below 50 per cent of their capacity, with the overall level dropping to marginally above 40 per cent this week, data from the Central Water Commission (CWC) revealed. The CWC’s weekly status on the major reservoirs showed that storage was 40.86 per cent or 74.999 billion cubic metres (BCM) of the 183.565 BCM capacity. The level was 14.7 percentage points higher than a year ago and 26.1 percentage points more than normal (past 10 years). Of the reservoirs, the level in 110 was below 50 per cent, with storage below 40 per cent in 78. Only 10 dams had storage above 80 per cent of their capacity.

34% RAIN DEFICIENT According to tje India Meteorological Department (IMD), data received from 725 districts show that 34 per cent of the country received deficient or no rainfall since March 1. The level in the southern region dropped to below 30 per cent of the 55.288 BCM capacity in 47 reservoirs. It was lower than 32 per cent a year ago. Storage in Telangana was the lowest in the region at 21 per cent, followed by Karnataka at 26 per cent.

The level in Andhra Pradesh was almost 40 per cent; it was 39 per cent in Tamil Nadu and 37.5 per cent in Kerala. In the eastern region too, storage was lower than 40 per cent of the capacity at 37 per cent. The situation in Assam and West Bengal was precarious with the level in two reservoirs in each in the States down to 17 per cent and 13 per cent, respectively. The level in Jharkhand was 54 per cent, while it was 37 per cent in Odisha. Meghalaya’s lone reservoir was filled to nearly 75 per cent. The western region had the highest storage, with the level in its 53 reservoirs being 48 per cent or 18.558 BCM of the 38.094 BCM capacity. **MORE DIP LIKELY** The level in the 28 reservoirs of the central region was 47.6 per cent of the 48.588 BCM capacity at 23.132 BCM. Storage in Chhattisgarh was 61 per cent, while in Madhya Pradesh, it was 49 per cent. Storage in Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhhand was 44 per cent and 33 per cent, respectively. In the northern region, storage in the 11 reservoirs was 44 per cent or 8743 BCM of the 19.836 BCM capacity. With the IMD predicting heatwaves across parts of the country, the level will likely decline further.

El Nino may return by mid-2026 amid warming seas, says WMO

Srikrishnan PC
Chennai

The World Meteorological Organization (WMO) has said that an El Nino event is likely to happen by the middle of 2026. The WMO’s global seasonal climate update said that the rising sea surface temperatures (SSTs) could trigger El Niño conditions between May and July. The report indicated that the land surface temperatures will be “nearly globally dominant” above normal for the next three months, and rainfall will be erratic. “After a period of neutral conditions at the start of the year, climate models are now strongly aligned, and there is high confidence in the onset of El Nino, followed by further intensification in the months that follow,” said

Wilfran Moufouma Okia, Chief of Climate Prediction at the WMO. “Models indicate that this may be a strong event, but the spring predictability barrier is a challenge for the certainty of forecasts at this time of year. Forecast confidence generally improves after April,” he said. **SPRING BARRIER** The spring predictability barrier is a limitation that reduces the skill of ENSO outlooks. Weaker ocean-atmosphere coupling and seasonal transition dynamics make climate models sensitive to background noise, limiting the reliability of long-range forecasts for El Nino and La Nina events until summer. In the past, El Nino events have led to either late arrival of the South-West monsoon

in India or deficient rain, besides prolonged dry spells. The India Meteorological Department has already predicted that it would be a below-normal monsoon this year, with the rainfall being 92 per cent of the long period average. In 2023, El Nino broke out in June and lasted for 11 months, affecting the Indian monsoon. It also resulted in 2024 being the warmest on record, as it continued until April 2024. It resulted in foodgrain crops, particularly paddy and pulses, being affected, leading to lower production. It also led to food inflation. According to the WMO report, southern South America, the southern US, the Horn of Africa and central Asia will get more rain. Australia, Indonesia and some parts of southern Asia will have less rain.

Global crude steel output fell 4.2% in March dragged by China’s production

Gayathri G
Chennai

Global crude steel production declined in March 2026, weighed down by sharp contractions in key producing regions even as India and a few others posted strong growth. According to the World Steel Association, output across 69 countries, accounting for about 98 per cent of global production, fell 4.2 per cent year-on-year to 159.9 million tonnes (mt). The downturn was largely driven by China, the number 1 steel producer, where output dropped 6.3 per cent to 87 mt in March. **INDIA, US** For the January-March period, China’s production was down 4.6 per cent at 247.6 mt.



In contrast, India maintained strong momentum, with production rising 9.4 per cent year-on-year to 15.3 mt in March and 10.8 per cent in the first quarter, reinforcing its position as the fastest-growing major producer. The output in the US was up 5.2 per cent to 7.2 mt in March, while Germany and Türkiye recorded increases of 7.5 per cent and 6.4 per cent, respectively. Across re-

gions, the trend remained uneven. **REGIONAL TRENDS** Asia and Oceania, which account for the bulk of global output, saw production fall 3.9 per cent to 119.3 mt; the EU recorded a 4.6 per cent decline to 11.4 mt. The Middle East’s output plunged by 33.5 per cent, while Russia and other CIS countries, along with Ukraine, reported a 7.9 per cent decline. In contrast, Africa and North America posted growth of 11.6 per cent and 3.5 per cent respectively, while production in “Europe, Other” rose 4.9 per cent. **QUARTERLY OUTPUT** For the first quarter of 2026 (Jan-March), global crude steel production stood at 459.2 mt, down 2.3 per cent from a year earlier.

QUICKLY.

₹5,000 cr sop for States to expedite mining auction

New Delhi: The government on Friday announced a financial incentive of ₹5,000 crore for the States to expedite the auction and operationalisation of mining blocks. The scheme will reward the States on a first-come, first-serve basis for streamlining the mining processes and adopting tech-driven monitoring, the Mines Ministry said in a statement. [PTI](#)

NSO proposes city-level statistical reports

New Delhi: The National Statistics Office (NSO), under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, has proposed to develop dedicated city-level statistical reports for 47 'million-plus' cities to bridge critical data gaps and support informed decision-making at all levels. The reports will be based on existing data from the Periodic Labour Force Survey and the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises, which allow estimation at the city level. [PTI](#)

Major jolt for AAP as seven of its 10 MPs in Rajya Sabha shift to BJP

FAULT LINE. BJP has once again betrayed Punjabis, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal says on social media

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) headed for a major split on Friday as seven of its 10 members in the Rajya Sabha joined the Bhartiya Janata Party (BJP).

The members include Raghav Chadda, Sandeep Phatak, Ashok Mittal, Harbhajan Singh, Rajinder Gupta, Vikramjeet Sahney, and Swati Maliwal. With this, the AAP will now have Sanjay Singh and Narain Dass Gupta from Delhi and Sant Balbir Singh from Punjab in the Rajya Sabha.

The party has three members — Raj Kumar Chabbewal, Gurmeet Singh Meet Hayer and Malvinder Singh Kang (all from Punjab) — in the Lok Sabha.

“As per the Constitution, two-thirds of the total MPs of a party can merge with another party. We have submitted a letter to Rajya Sabha



SWEET BEGINNINGS. BJP National President Nitin Nabin (fourth from right) with Raghav Chadha (third from right) and other MPs at the party's headquarters in New Delhi [PTI](#)

Chairman CP Radhakrishnan in this regard today, along with all the required documents,” Chadha announced at a press conference here which was also attended by Mittal and Pathak. Since the numbers represent more than 2/3rd of the total strength of the party in the Rajya Sabha, they will not face action under the

anti-defection law. “The BJP has once again betrayed Punjabis,” AAP National Convener Arvind Kejriwal said in a post on X.

TERMED TRAITORS Reacting to the development, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann dubbed the AAP's Rajya Sabha members

who quit the party as “gad-dars” (traitors). “BJP was trying to break the AAP and had betrayed the people of Punjab. When they did not find anything against Bhagwant Mann, they tried to break AAP,” said Mann.

According to him, the BJP is perturbed why Mann is becoming the leader of the people. “People of Punjab are with the AAP; they firmly stand with the party,” he said, adding that the party is bigger than an individual, and 6-7 people who have left do not comprise Punjab.

‘UNFORGIVABLE’ Sanjay Singh, AAP MP, said: “The people of Punjab should remember these seven names. They will never forgive those who have betrayed them.”

He claimed that the party made Chadha an MLA and an MP. “What did the people of Punjab not give him? How much love did they show by

sending him to the Rajya Sabha? And now, he has gone into the lap of the BJP.”

“The party gave Sandeep Pathak the opportunity to reach the Rajya Sabha with the love and blessings of the people of Punjab and entrusted him with major responsibilities. Rajendra Gupta, look at his journey and how far the party took him to the Rajya Sabha,” Singh said.

Further, Vikram Sahney, Ashok Mittal and Swati Maliwal were all elevated by the AAP and the people of Punjab from the grassroots to the Rajya Sabha. Even Harbhajan Singh was given the opportunity to reach Parliament with the love and blessings of the people of Punjab. But these individuals had stabbed the people of Punjab in the back.

“They have betrayed them and have worked to obstruct a government in Punjab that was serving the people,” Singh said.

Policybazaar’s Gift City arm sees over 50% NRI customer share

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Policybazaar is seeing strong early traction from its operations in Gift City, with non-resident Indians from the US, the UAE and the UK driving demand for its dollar-denominated insurance-linked investment products.

The platform, which expanded into Gift City through a branch in September 2025, has enabled NRIs across 35 countries to access investment-linked insurance

products denominated in US dollars.

According to Lakshit Mahajan, Head of NRI Investment Business at Policybazaar, the Gift City channel is generating high-value transactions, with a minimum monthly premium of about \$200 and top-ticket sizes reaching up to \$15,000. “Gift City now contributes to more than 50 per cent of our NRI customer base in terms of total premium value. These are high-value transactions,” Mahajan said. He added that within this

‘In terms of volume, NRI customers from Gift City account for about 25% of total users in this segment’

base, around 30 per cent of customers are from the US, 25 per cent from the UAE and 10 per cent from the UK, indicating early concentration in key global diaspora markets.

In terms of volume, NRI customers from Gift City account for about 25 per cent of total users in the segment, he noted.

PREFERRED HUB Gift City is emerging as a preferred investment destination for NRIs, supported by features such as tax-free gains under Section 10 (10D), access to US dollar-denominated market-linked insurance products, seamless repatriation and a single unified regulator under the International Financial Ser-

vices Centres Authority (IFSCA). Mahajan said Policybazaar's IFSC Insurance Intermediary Office in Gift City operates as a comparison platform similar to its domestic business, allowing users to evaluate and purchase products digitally.

NRIs can invest directly through NRE or overseas bank accounts, with fully digital onboarding, remote KYC and no requirement for physical presence.

Customers can choose from international funds as well as gold and silver ETFs,

with flexibility in premium payments and partial withdrawals. Certain policies also offer tax benefits, while Double Taxation Avoidance Agreements help reduce the risk of double taxation across jurisdictions.

The company also noted a strong skew toward younger investors, with nearly two-thirds of its NRI customer base in the 28-45 age group, highlighting growing participation from digitally active, globally mobile professionals allocating to dollar-based instruments.

Peak power demand crosses 240 GW in April

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Peak power demand surged to a seasonal high of 240 GW on Thursday, driven by intense heat and increased air conditioner usage, according to the latest Power Ministry data.

The country's peak power demand met (the highest supply in a day) was recorded a tad higher at 240.12 GW on April 23, up from 239.70 GW the previous day, the highest in this summer.

According to experts, the peak power demand may soon breach the second-highest recorded at 243.27 GW in September 2023, with rising mercury levels and an increase in the intensity of heat waves in the country.

The record high of 250 GW of peak power demand was recorded in May 2024. Last year, the peak power demand was 242.77 GW, which was recorded in June 2025.

Kashmir handicraft sector hit as West Asia conflict stalls exports, weakens demand

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

Nearly two months after the outbreak of the conflict in Iran, Kashmir's handicraft industry is facing a growing crisis, with consignments stuck in the Valley and shipments to key Gulf markets remaining suspended, exporters said.

Trade representatives said fresh orders had dropped sharply, payments had been delayed and inventories were piling up as uncertainty linked to the conflict continued to disrupt trade routes and dampen buyer sentiment.

Javed Ahmad Tenga, exporter and President of the Kashmir Chamber of Commerce and Industry, said consignments meant for the West Asian markets had been stranded since the onset of the conflict. “Even bulk shipments



JOBS AT RISK. Official data show that the sector employs more than 4.4 lakh artisans, making it the second-largest employment generator in the region after agriculture [IMRAN NISSAR](#)

destined for the West Asian markets during Ramadhan remain stalled in the Valley,” Tenga said.

PEAK TIME HIT

He said Ramadhan, typically the peak export season for Kashmiri handicrafts, saw an unusual downturn this year, with demand for items such as prayer rugs, carpets and papier-mâché products re-

maining weak. The season, which ended on March 21, recorded “little to no orders,” marking a sharp deviation from normal trends, he added.

The Gulf region accounts for a major share of Kashmir's handicraft exports, and the ongoing disruption had triggered a liquidity crunch across the sector, affecting thousands of artisans,

weavers and small exporters dependent on overseas demand.

Official data show the sector employs more than 4.4 lakh artisans, making it the second-largest employment generator in the region after agriculture.

“We have stopped producing new items as sales have declined significantly due to the conflict,” said Bashir Ahmad, a papier-mâché artisan in Srinagar.

He said the industry had already suffered due to the Russia-Ukraine war.

Kashmir's handicraft exports have nearly doubled over the past five years, rising from about ₹1,000 crore to ₹2,000 crore, according to industry estimates. However, exporters warn that the current disruption threatens to slow the sector's growth momentum as key overseas markets remain uncertain and trade flows weaken further.

L&T enters B2B electronics products manufacturing space

Our Bureau
Chennai

Infrastructure major L&T has entered the B2B industrial electronics space with the commencement of industrial electronics manufacturing at its Coimbatore campus in Tamil Nadu, the company said on Friday.

The new business vertical, christened L&T Electronic Products & Systems (LTEPS), will be headquartered in Bengaluru, while the manufacturing operations will be based in Coimbatore.

To begin with, two manufacturing lines have been commissioned, offering electronics manufacturing services to both Indian and global clients. “The foray into industrial electronics is an important step towards our Lakshya 2031 aspiration of deepening technology

Textile exports inch up 2% in FY26 on weak rupee

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The textile sector displayed resilience in FY26 in the backdrop of steep US tariffs and the West Asia crisis.

Exports rose 2.1 per cent to ₹3.16 lakh crore, compared with ₹3.09 lakh crore in FY25, said the Textiles Ministry.

However, in dollar terms, exports declined 2.2 per cent, indicating pressure on real earnings, according to industry sources.

Export growth was recorded across more than 120 destinations, including the UAE, the UK, Germany, Spain and Japan, underscoring sustained global demand and India's competitiveness across product segments.

The Ministry of Textiles attributed the performance to steady demand and policy support measures, such as export facilitation and re-mission schemes.

Ready-made garments continued to lead exports, growing 2.9 per cent to ₹1.39 lakh crore from ₹1.35 lakh crore. Cotton yarn, fabrics, made-ups and handloom products remained largely stable at ₹1.02 lakh crore, registering a marginal growth of 0.4 per cent.

Man-made yarn, fabrics and made-ups posted a stronger increase of 3.6 per cent to ₹42,687.8 crore. Among the value-added segments, handicrafts (excluding handmade carpets) saw the highest growth, rising 6.1 per cent to ₹15,855 crore.

DROP IN \$ TERMS

However, Ajay Srivastava, Founder, Global Trade Research Initiative, cautioned that the growth was largely “optical”.

While exports increased 2.1 per cent in rupee terms, they fell 2.2 per cent in dollar terms — from \$36.6 billion



Ready-made garments continued to lead exports, growing to ₹1.39 lakh crore from ₹1.35 lakh crore [BHOJO GHOSH](#)

to \$35.8 billion — implying lower real earnings from global markets. Across segments, the pattern remained consistent: Cotton (-3.9 per cent), garments (-1.4 per cent), carpets (-5.3 per cent) and jute (-6.9 per cent) all declined in dollar terms, even as the rupee values showed mild gains.

RUPEE VALUE DIPS

“This gap is not a sign of strength but of currency effect — rupee depreciation inflating domestic values without improving export competitiveness,” Srivastava said, warning that India is losing ground in labour-intensive sectors and that deeper structural reforms are needed.

According to Aniket Dani, Director, Crisis Intelligence, Indian garment exports managed to defy expectations despite the imposition of a 50 per cent reciprocal tariff by the US.

The sector also stepped up diversification, expanding exports into non-traditional destinations such as Malaysia, Nigeria and Brazil. Progress on India's Free Trade Agreement agenda during 2025-26 is expected to have positive implications for the sector, the government statement noted.

IRFC nod for ₹13,615 cr loan for Telangana to acquire L&T Metro

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) has agreed to extend a ₹13,615 crore loan to the Telangana government for the takeover of Hyderabad Metro Rail from L&T Metro Rail Hyderabad. The State Cabinet was informed that Hyderabad Metro had approved the loan with a repayment period of 20 years, with a guarantee from the State government.

The legal formalities for availing the loan and procedural aspects of the takeover will have to be worked out, said official sources. A formal announcement is likely soon.

In February, the State Cabinet had approved the acquisition of a 100 per cent equity stake in Phase I of the project.

Wonderla unveils skywheel in Chennai, expects footfalls of 7-8 lakh in FY27

Rohan Das
Chennai

The 80-metre skywheel at Wonderla Chennai rounds off the theme park here.

The fully air-conditioned ride includes a sky view diner, an air-conditioned elevated dining space located within the structure. The ride has been built at a cost of ₹37 crore.

Built at an investment of ₹611 crore, Wonderla Chennai opened in December of last year and can entertain up to 6,500 visitors everyday. The facility recorded revenues of ₹12 crore in its first month of operations and saw over 75,000 visitors in December alone.

THRILL SEEKERS

Speaking to *businessline*, Arun K Chittilappilly, Executive Chairman and Man-



aging Director, Wonderla Holidays, said that the company is expecting strong footfall from the Chennai park in FY27 and that it should soon compete with the company's establishments in other cities.

“We have seen strong footfalls in our Chennai park even though it has been only 3-4 months. Now that it is fully complete, the footfall should grow at a steady rate and we expect that it will soon compete with our Bengaluru, Kochi and Hy-

derabad parks,” he said.

He added that the company is also looking at Chennai as one of the locations for its next resort offering. It had recently announced the launch of Terrea by Wonderla, an earth-inspired urban resort adjacent to its Bengaluru park, which was revamped over eight months on an investment of around ₹18 crore.

As for the company's future plans, Chittilappilly said that it is now in discussions to open its next park with Mumbai, Indore, Ahmedabad and Goa being evaluated as prospective locations.

Chittilappilly added that the Wonderla is also looking at adjacent businesses such as virtual indoor entertainment and content creation but said these plans are in the early phase.

BlueStone sees steady demand amid gold swings

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Bengaluru-based jewellery retailer Bluestone has not seen any softening in consumer demand despite heightened volatility in gold prices and rising macroeconomic uncertainty, according to Gaurav Singh Kushwaha, Founder and CEO.

In India, gold jewellery demand fell about 26 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) in the first half of FY26, even as the demand for bars and coins rose 15 per cent, signalling a shift towards investment-led buying amid price volatility and global uncertainty, per a ICRA-Assocham Report.

However, BlueStone's experience diverges from this trend.

“If there is any softening, we don't see it in our data. In fact, as we have grown, de-

mand has only strengthened,” Kushwaha said.

Financially, the company reported strong traction for the quarter, with standalone revenue from operations rising 38 per cent y-o-y to ₹687.7 crore.

The company also swung back to profitability, posting a net profit of ₹36.4 crore as compared to a loss of ₹48.6 crore in the previous quarter.

Rising daily expenses, partly driven by geopolitical tensions and input cost inflation, are squeezing discretionary spending. Consumers are recalibrating, opting for lower ticket sizes or more frequent purchases of lighter pieces. The growth in the quarter was led by store expansion and strong same-store performance, with existing outlets clocking about 34 per cent growth.

MELSS, US-based Valtech float JV for manufacturing specialty chemicals

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

MEL Systems and Services, an engineering and technology solutions company serving electronics, aerospace and defence sectors, signed a joint venture (JV) with US-based Valtech Corporation on Friday to strengthen supply chain for the semiconductor and solar power sector.

The JV, MELSS Valtech Ltd, will set up a manufacturing unit in Chennai to produce chemicals, plastic products used in the manufacture of solar cells and semiconductor devices.

“With India's keen focus on promoting semicon fab and OSAT facilities, we see potential in this venture,” N Ramachandran, Executive Chairman, MELSS, told *busi-*



Robert Girard, President and CEO, Valtech Corporation and Shivkumar Srinivasan, MD, MELSS [BHOJO GHOSH](#)

nessline. “We plan to start production at this facility as early as by October and in the first phase, it is not very capital intensive,” he added. “Our idea is to source locally as much as possible,” he said. Besides global sourcing of capital goods and equipment needed for the semicon sector, MELSS also has business

lines, including digital transformation of factories, building automatic test equipment, and designing and building simulators for railways and the defence sector. Valtech is a global specialty chemical manufacturer of high-performance products for diverse market applications.

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QUICKLY.

**Alkem Labs CEO
Vikas Gupta resigns**

Mumbai: Alkem Laboratories Limited disclosed on Friday that its Chief Executive Officer, Vikas Gupta, has resigned from the position. Gupta will remain in his role until June 30 to ensure a smooth handover of leadership responsibilities. No successor has been named as yet. In his resignation letter, Gupta cited personal and long-term professional goals as reasons for his departure. Markets reacted negatively to the announcement. Alkem's shares on the NSE fell 5.17 per cent to ₹5,235 on Friday. **OUR BUREAU**

US to levy anti-dumping duty on Indian solar cells

New Delhi: The US Department of Commerce has announced preliminary anti-dumping duty on imports of solar cells and panels from India. It has been alleged that solar cells from India are being sold in the US below the fair value. The department's notice lists four Indian manufacturers — Mundra Solar PV, Mundra Solar Energy, Kowa Company and Premier Energy Photovoltaic.

Dr Reddy's semaglutide gets Health Canada nod

Hyderabad: Dr Reddy's Laboratories has received the Drug Identification Numbers (DINs) for semaglutide injection from Health Canada as part of the consideration for its approval. Last month, Dr Reddy's launched its injectable semaglutide under the brand name Obeda for the management of type 2 diabetes in the Indian market. It was the first Indian company to receive the Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI) approval for generic semaglutide. **OUR BUREAU**

Top four IT firms report increase in revenue per employee in FY26

PROJECT DELIVERY. Growth was driven by rationalisation of headcount and gains from automation

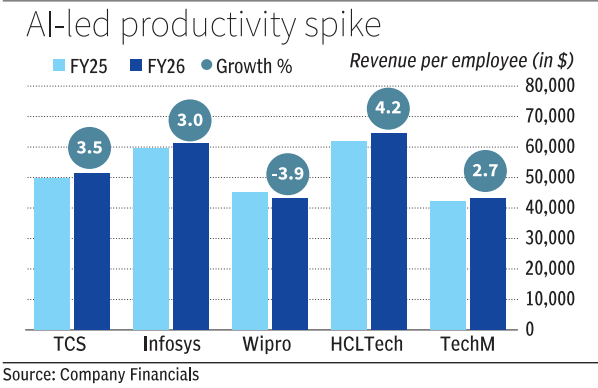
**Rohan Das
Chennai**

The traditional IT services model of growth in revenue complemented by a proportionate spike in headcount seems to be undergoing a change as companies are drawing more revenue out of each employee.

According to data from company financials, four among the five major Tier 1 Indian IT players have seen a 3-4 per cent increase in revenue per employee for the financial year ending March 2026, when compared to the previous fiscal.

This is slightly higher than the roughly 2-2.5 per cent growth in FY25 compared to FY24.

GROWTH NUMBERS
Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), for instance, posted \$51,360 in revenue per em-



ployee, up 3.5 per cent from \$49,638 for the year ending March 2025.

For Infosys, the revenue per employee went up by 3 per cent to \$61,350, while Tech Mahindra saw a 2.7 per cent uptick to \$43,260.

HCLTech saw the largest increase, going up by 4.2 per cent to \$61,350. Interestingly, the company had also seen a large increase of 6.2 per cent in this metric for

FY25 as against FY24.

Wipro, however, bucked the trend posting a degrowth in revenue per employee at \$43,270 down 3.9 per cent from FY25.

Speaking to *businessline*, analysts said that growth is driven by both rationalisation in total headcount and early productivity gains from automation and AI being embedded in project delivery. According to Biswajeet

Mahapatra, Principal Analyst, Forrester, AI is accounting for roughly one quarter to one third of the improvement in revenue per employee.

“The impact comes from an AI-driven task level efficiency in coding, testing, service management and documentation,” he said.

Kapil Joshi, CEO-IT Staffing, Quess Corp, said that the use of generative AI tools in coding, testing and design is also expected to improve margins by 100-200 bps.

“In addition, large-scale reskilling initiatives, where each leading firm has upskilled 10,000 to 80,000 employees in AI and related technologies, are enabling teams to work faster and more efficiently,” he said.

UTILISATION RATE
Joshi also highlighted that better utilisation rate at about 84-87 per cent and a

higher concentration of off-shore delivery have played its part.

AI PRODUCTIVITY
Francis Padamadan, CEO, Xpheno, a specialist staffing firm, however, believes that efficiencies drawn from AI use in the Indian IT services players are not yet strong enough to make them replace human resource.

“The optimisation of headcounts is more revenue outlook and cost pressures driven, rather than powered by an AI lift in productivity,” he said.

TCS's net headcount as of Q4 FY26 was 3.9 per cent lower than the same quarter last year while Infosys and HCLTech recorded growth of 1.5 per cent and 1.7 per cent respectively. Wipro's headcount went up by 3.7 per cent as against Tech Mahindra, which went down by 0.75 per cent.

Groupe ADP to sell up to 7.3 per cent stake in GMR Airports

**Our Bureau
New Delhi**

French airport operator Groupe ADP has signed agreements with the GMR Promoter Group to sell securities representing up to 7.3 per cent of the equity share capital of GMR Airports Ltd (GAL).

According to a Groupe ADP statement, the deal includes the early purchase of convertible bonds held by the French airport operator by the GMR Promoter Group.

The transaction is expected to generate overall post-

tax cash proceeds of about €924 million.

Accordingly, the agreements comprise three separate arrangements.

In the first phase, completed on Friday, Groupe ADP sold 3.4 per cent of GAL's ordinary equity shares to GMR Group for €256 million.

CALL OPTIONS
Besides, GMR Group has been granted call options, while Groupe ADP retains corresponding put options, for securities representing 3.9 per cent of GAL's ordinary equity shares for an estimated €285 million.

Any transfer arising from the exercise of these options is scheduled to be completed no later than April 30, 2027, the statement said.

Furthermore, GMR Group will undertake the early purchase of Foreign Currency Convertible Bonds (FCCBs) held by Groupe ADP, with a nominal value of €301 million plus accrued interest.

This transaction is expected to conclude by March 31, 2027.

GOVERNANCE RIGHTS
As per Groupe ADP, its governance rights in GAL and co-promoter status will re-



As per Groupe ADP, its governance rights in GAL and co-promoter status will remain unchanged following completion of the transaction

main unchanged following completion of the transaction.

The French airport operator stated that the arrangement rebalances the economic exposure between Groupe ADP and GMR Group while maintaining their long-term partnership without requiring any additional capital injection.

The company said the transaction aligns with its strategy to optimise the financial contribution of international assets.

Notably, Groupe ADP added that the sale enables it to crystallise part of GAL's value appreciation since its acquisition in 2020, while preserving exposure to future growth.

Infosys approves ₹52 cr stock grant for CEO

**Our Bureau
Bengaluru**



Infosys CEO Salil Parekh

IT giant Infosys has approved stock incentives worth ₹51.75 crore for its Chief Operating Officer and Managing Director, Salil Parekh, according to the company's regulatory filing.

The filing on Thursday revealed that the board approved the annual grants to Parekh based on the recommendations of the nomination and remuneration committee, in line with the employment agreement approved by the shareholders. These grants are part of Parekh's annual performance-linked compensation structure.

STOCK INCENTIVES
The grant of annual performance-based stock incentives is in the form of restricted stock units (RSUs) covering the company's equity shares, having a market value of ₹34.75 crore. The stock incentives will include an ESG-based annual performance equity award worth ₹2 crore,

aiming at environmental, social and governance targets.

Additionally, he will receive around ₹15 crore in terms of performance-based shares. These will be split into a ₹5 crore RSU grant that will vest on or after March 31, 2027, subject to the two-year cumulative relative total shareholder return, and a ₹10 crore RSU grant that will vest post 12 months, subject to certain targets being met.

The total value of the grants is approximately ₹51.75 crore, with vesting scheduled over one to two years, contingent on board-defined performance conditions and milestones.

West Asia war hits air travel, international passenger traffic slumps 18.5 % in March

**Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai**

Passenger traffic at Indian airports fell 4.4 per cent on year-on-year basis to 34.5 million in March dragged down by 18.5 per cent drop in international volume, data compiled by Airports Authority of India (AAI) show.

While domestic traffic declined by 1.3 per cent to 29.1 million, international footfalls fell sharply by 18.5 per cent to 5.3 million as a consequence of the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

Previously, a decline in traffic was registered last December due to disruption of IndiGo's flights.

PUNE SHOWS GROWTH
Among the country's 10 busiest airports — only Pune showed growth of 8.1 per cent in traffic (domestic plus international). Growth at



SIGNIFICANT SLIDE. The biggest drop of 12 per cent in traffic was seen in Hyderabad and Kochi

Bengaluru was flat while Delhi airport showed minor 0.2 per cent decline in traffic. The biggest drop of 12 per cent in traffic was seen in Hyderabad and Kochi, AAI data show.

Indian and overseas carriers cut flights due to airspace restrictions last month. Air India Express flew 60 per

cent fewer international flights in March on a month-on-month basis and IndiGo had 35 per cent less flights.

AIRSPACE CURBS
While airspace restrictions in West Asia are being eased, Indian carriers are still not operating to Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar.

Within the international segment biggest percentage drop in traffic was seen at Nagpur (93.7), Kannur (92.4), Goa Dabolim (85.3) and Madurai (84).

While Kochi and Thiruvananthapuram saw 36 per cent and 38 per cent decline in international traffic, Kozhikode saw a drop of 47.4 per cent.

Travel agents say demand for outbound travel in May remains muted with high airfares.

“Demand for domestic travel is at similar level or slightly higher compared to last year but demand for overseas travel is down 25-30 per cent due to higher airfares, rupee depreciation and general safety issues as West Asia remains tense despite ceasefire,” said Rajiv Mehra, General Secretary, Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism and Hospitality.

Nitu Samra named interim CEO of Noida International Airport

**Our Bureau
New Delhi**



Nitu Samra, interim CEO, Noida International Airport

Noida International Airport (NIA) on Friday appointed Nitu Samra as Chief Executive Officer on an interim basis with immediate effect. She succeeds Christoph Schnellmann.

The move follows directions issued by the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) requiring that airport Chief Executive Officers in India have to be Indian nationals.

SELECTION PROCESS
As per NIA, Samra will serve in the role until the Board of Directors completes a formal selection process.

She has been serving as the Chief Financial Officer of NIA since October 2021.

Besides, Schnellmann, who led the airport as Chief Executive Officer since Au-

gust 2020, will move to the Board of Directors as Executive Vice Chairman.

REVISED STRUCTURE
In this capacity, NIA said that he will continue to support the airport's development and its transition into operations.

Notably, the leadership restructuring comes after the inauguration of Noida Inter-

national Airport in March 2026.

The airport stated that the revised structure is intended to support operational readiness while ensuring regulatory compliance.

SMOOTH TRANSITION
According to Daniel Bircher, Chairman of Yamuna International Airport Private Limited, the management transition was aimed at enabling the airport to commence operations at the earliest while meeting BCAS requirements.

Bircher stated that the revised leadership structure would help maintain continuity in governance and support a smooth transition into operations.

He added that the Noida International Airport would continue to operate under transparent governance practices and an established corporate culture.

Delhi airport's Pier C at T3 ready for international ops from May

**Rohit Vaid
New Delhi**

The Pier C at Terminal 3 (T3) of Delhi airport will commence international operations from the first week of May, marking the operational rollout of the facility's conversion from domestic to international use.

Earlier this week, *businessline* reported that the conversion of Pier C at T3 had been completed and was awaiting regulatory clearance before becoming operational. The move is aimed at expanding international handling capacity and strengthening Delhi Airport's hub ambitions.

On its part, Delhi International Airport Limited (DIAL), the repurposed Pier C will increase Delhi Airport's international passenger handling capacity at Terminal 3 by around 50 per cent, adding nearly 10 million passengers annually.

This is expected to take T3's international capacity to around 30-32 million passengers per annum.

TRANSIT HUB
As per DIAL, the conversion forms part of a broader strategy to strengthen Delhi Airport's position as an international aviation transit hub amid rising global traffic and increasing long-haul connectivity.

Notably Pier C, which has been part of Terminal 3 since its inception, has been converted from domestic to international operations through repurposing of existing infrastructure without new construction. The exercise, DIAL said was aimed at unlocking latent terminal capacity while improving passenger movement and operational resilience.

According to Videh Kumar Jaipuria, Chief Executive Officer of DIAL, the conversion reflects the airport's strategy of expanding capacity through existing infrastructure while preparing for future demand.

Vodafone-Idea mobile tariffs to see ‘minor corrections’

**Our Bureau
New Delhi**

Telecom services provider Vodafone-Idea (Vi) on Friday said it has no plan to go for an across-the-board hike in mobile tariff and may opt for only minor corrections in the existing rates.

“Minor corrections will be there but not a structural hike as you generally see... Ongoing minor tariff corrections driven by current market conditions,” Abhijit Kishore, Chief Executive Officer, Vi, said here on the sidelines of the Cellular Operators Association of India DigiCom Summit 2026.

HISTORICAL TRENDS
Recently, Bharti Airtel increased prepaid mobile recharge plans by around 4-5



per cent, and analysts have projected that telecom operators may raise tariff by about 15 per cent by June this year, two years after the last major adjustments, a timeline that aligns with historical industry trends.

Analysts said that recharge price hike and strategic pricing adjustments are expected to accelerate sector revenue growth to 16 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) in FY27, a significant jump

from the estimated 7 per cent y-o-y growth for FY26.

Meanwhile, Kishore said that the government has shown confidence in the company as a significant shareholder and the focus is on improving performance.

SUBSCRIBER ADDITION
“The government is a 49 per cent stakeholder and we really value that. We are working towards what we should be doing, which is basically improving the performance, which is what you see on the subscriber initiative,” he added.

After recording a decline in subscriber base in the last few years, the company added over one lakh mobile subscribers in March, according to the latest report by the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India.

BMW's India pack has 10 Minis, 15 cars, 2 bikes

**Amit Vijay Mohile
Goa**



BMW Group India is executing one of its most comprehensive market pushes yet, anchored around a major expansion of its iconic British brand Mini with 10 new product actions in CY26, as it looks to move beyond niche luxury positioning.

The plan includes 15 new BMW passenger vehicles and two from BMW Motorrad — taking the total roll-out to 27 — alongside a broader push spanning local manufacturing, electric vehicles, motorcycles and retail expansion.

MINI, BUT BIG SALES
In CY25, BMW retail 18,001 cars — up 14 per cent — of which Mini accounted for 730 units.

This year, on the back of 10 product actions, BMW is targeting close to 1,500 Mini units. The shift is anchored

in localisation. The Mini Countryman currently sits as a largely imported line-up, with the electric Countryman E priced from ₹55.65 lakh, the JCW Countryman All4 at ₹66.15 lakh and the Countryman SE All4 at ₹67.40 lakh.

“We are not choosing between electric and petrol — we are growing both,” said Hardeep Singh Brar, President and CEO of BMW Group India, speaking at the F 450 GS launch.

BMW Motorrad is using

its twin-cylinder platform to disrupt the sub-500 cc segment. The BMW F 450 GS, launched on April 23, is priced between ₹4.7 lakh and ₹5.3 lakh, positioning it as the most accessible entry into its GS adventure touring line-up.

SUPPLY-LIMITED
At roughly 6,000 units in CY25, BMW Motorrad India is supply-limited rather than demand-constrained, leaving potential volumes unrealised.

BMW sees continued growth across segments, with the premium motorcycle category expected to expand at over 10 per cent.

However, one structural constraint remains outside its control.

“GST changes are not in favour because of the higher taxation on bigger bikes,” Brar said, referring to the 28 per cent levy on motorcycles above 350CC. The F450 GS

is manufactured at TVS Motor's Hosur facility, deepening a partnership that is becoming central to BMW Motorrad's India strategy. “It clearly shows that you can manufacture world-class quality in Indian manufacturing facilities,” Brar said. As BMW scales its locally produced motorcycle portfolio, the TVS relationship is shifting from a tactical arrangement to a structural pillar — supporting localisation, cost efficiency and volume expansion.

SIGNIFICANT GROWTH
On the car side, BMW has continued to outperform in a sluggish market. While the broader passenger vehicle segment grew 6-7 per cent and the luxury segment remained flat last year, BMW delivered double-digit growth quarter-on-quarter.

The writer was in Goa at the invitation of BMW India

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